VAULT-TEC ARCHIVE · DOCTORAL THESIS

FELIX CONTAMINATIO

Vault, Vat, and Garden in the Immunopolitical Theology of Fallout *(1997) and* Fallout 2 *(1998)*



A DOCTORAL THESIS

FILED 23 OCTOBER 2026

FIFTY-ONE YEARS BEFORE 23 OCTOBER 2077

FILE 00 · ABSTRACT

ABSTRACT

THIS THESIS ARGUES THAT *Fallout* (Interplay Productions, 1997) and *Fallout 2* (Black Isle Studios, 1998) compose a single philosophical diptych whose object is not nuclear catastrophe as event but *fallout* as remainder: the persistence, after the end of the world, of the logics that ended it. Against readings that treat the Interplay-era games as an ironic pastiche of Atomic Age kitsch, *Mad Max* iconography, and Hobbesian survivalism, it reconstructs from their quest architectures, factional ideologies, and procedural systems a rigorous immunopolitical theology organized around three paradigmatic devices: the Vault, the Vat, and the Garden.

The Vault—Vault-Tec's sealed social laboratory, and its successors in the Brotherhood of Steel's bunker, Vault City's citizenship regime, and the Enclave's oil platform—names sovereignty as *immunity* in Roberto Esposito's sense: protection purchased through enclosure, stasis, and the expulsion of whatever has been exposed. The Vat—the Master's cisterns of Forced Evolutionary Virus, a technology that, by the series' own documentation, began life as a program of "pan-immunity"—names sovereignty as *unity*: the dream of abolishing the political by fusing difference into a single fabricated species, a counterfeit baptism whose issue is sterile. The Garden—the Garden of Eden Creation Kit—names the commodified promise of re-creation, whose ethical valence the sequel renders undecidable by placing at its center Vault City, an Edenic enclave founded with precisely such a kit and sustained by servitude. Read together, the three devices disclose a shared anti-natal structure in Hannah Arendt's sense: the Vault arrests time, the Vat forecloses birth, and the Enclave's purity virus would exterminate the impure majority in whom any future must be born.

The central claim is that the series' refrain, "War never changes," is not a fatalist philosophy of history but a *definition*: of war, and of the sovereignty that wages it, as the immutable. Against the immutable the games set the mutant—etymologically, the one who has changed—as the bearer of history. The Vault Dweller, exiled from Vault 13 for having changed, and the Chosen One, a "tribal" whom the last government of the United States classifies as a mutant, are figures of what I term *exilic natality*: the capacity to begin that arises only from exposure. From this follows the governing concept of *felix contaminatio*, a secular inversion of the *felix culpa* in which contamination, not purity, is the condition of a livable future.

The argument proceeds through sustained engagement with the philosophical lineages the games mobilize—Heraclitus, Plato, Aristotle, Hobbes, Locke, Rousseau, Hegel, Nietzsche, Weber, Heidegger, Arendt, Foucault, Agamben, Esposito, Haraway,

and Nancy—and through comparison with a speculative tradition running from Shelley, Wells, and Forster through Huxley, Wyndham, Miller, Dick, Hoban, Butler, and Miyazaki. A final movement contends that the games' ludic form—nonlinear, ergodic, generically impure, and organized by an attribute schema whose acronym rhymes uncannily with Philip K. Dick's irradiated "specials"—is itself the procedural enactment of *felix contaminatio*. The result is a reading of the Interplay-era *Fallout* as one of the most philosophically consequential works of late-twentieth-century speculative fiction, and as a theory of community adequate to an age of permanent contamination.

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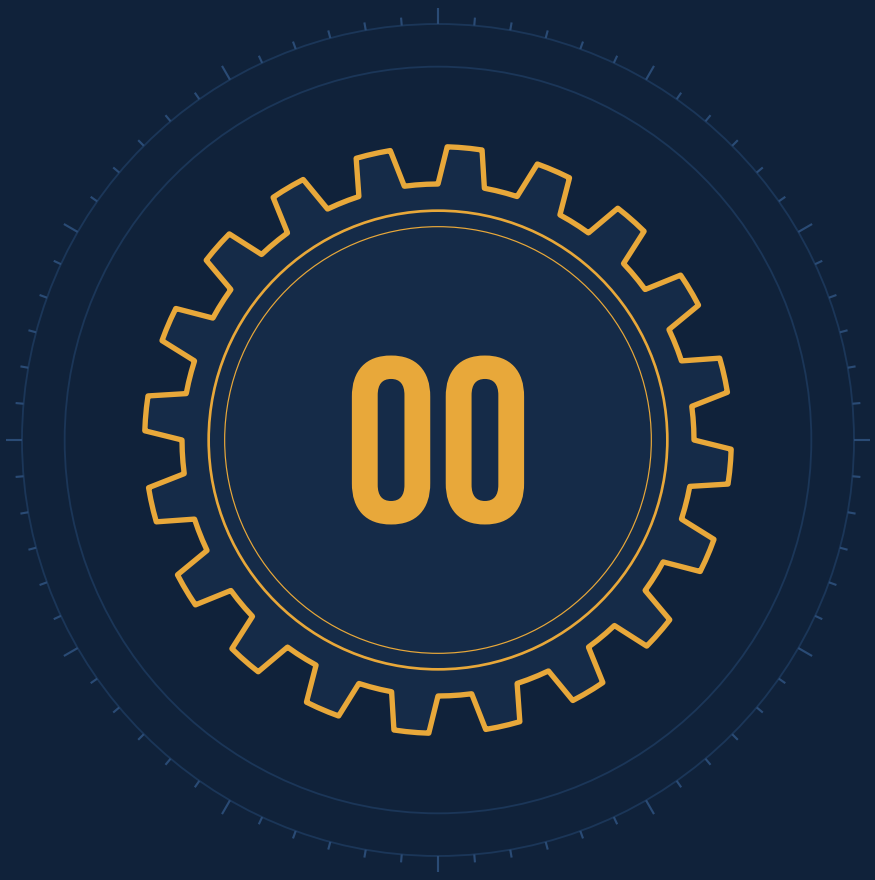
A NOTE ON CORPUS, ATTRIBUTION, AND METHOD

Corpus. The primary texts are *Fallout: A Post Nuclear Role Playing Game* (Interplay Productions, 1997) and *Fallout 2: A Post Nuclear Role Playing Game* (Black Isle Studios, published by Interplay, 1998), together with their printed manuals, their in-game documents (holodisks, terminal records, epilogue narration), and their dialogue trees. Chris Avellone's *Fallout Bible*, serialized online in 2002, is treated as a paratext of uneven authority: cited where it clarifies, never permitted to overrule what the games themselves make legible. Later installments—*Fallout Tactics* (2001), the Bethesda-era titles inaugurated by *Fallout 3* (2008), Obsidian's *Fallout: New Vegas* (2010), and the 2024 television adaptation—appear only as comparanda or afterlives.

Attribution. The phrase "Cain and Boyarsky" functions here as a metonym, in the sense of Foucault's author-function ("What Is an Author?", 1969), for a collective and institutionally mediated authorship. *Fallout* was initiated by Tim Cain, who served as its producer and lead programmer; Leonard Boyarsky directed its art and fixed the retro-futurist idiom that became the series' signature; Jason D. Anderson, lead designer Christopher Taylor, Scott Campbell, and a wider company of designers and writers built its world under executive producer Brian Fargo, with Feargus Urquhart as division director. The project began as a licensed adaptation of Steve Jackson Games' *GURPS* system, working-titled *Vault 13*; the dissolution of that partnership—after Steve Jackson Games objected, by Cain's account, to the game's violence and art, an account the licensor has questioned, and by a decision Interplay's executives took—produced the bespoke S.P.E.C.I.A.L. schema, devised by Cain and Christopher Taylor and analyzed in Chapter 8. *Fallout* was made by Interplay's in-house role-playing team, the nucleus of the division that by 1998 was branded Black Isle Studios, under whose name *Fallout 2* appeared, completed under Urquhart—credited on it as producer, lead designer, and division director—and written and designed by a staff that included Chris Avellone. Cain, Boyarsky, and Anderson had been assigned to the sequel within a month of the first game's release but left early in its development—Cain resigning in January 1998—to found Troika Games; Urquhart and Matt Norton then directed it, so the original team's groundwork reaches the finished sequel only in part. The two games are therefore treated as one work of many hands: a diptych whose coherence is philosophical rather than biographical.

Method. Three protocols are braided throughout. The first is philosophical hermeneutics in Gadamer's sense: the games are interrogated as bearers of claims, and their horizon is fused with the traditions whose concepts they set in motion, whether by citation, structural homology, or ironic inversion. The second is procedural criticism after Espen Aarseth and Ian Bogost, for which rules are propositions: a time limit is a claim about finitude; a barter screen is a theory of value; an Intelligence attribute that gates dialogue is an epistemology; a Karma counter is a moral metaphysics; an epilogue slideshow is an eschatology. The third is comparative, situating the games within the speculative tradition and its theory—Darko Suvin's cognitive estrangement, Fredric Jameson's account of science fiction as the defamiliarization of the present, and the "nuclear criticism" convened by *Diacritics* in 1984.

The compound *immunopolitical theology* fuses Carl Schmitt's thesis that the significant concepts of modern politics are secularized theological concepts with Esposito's immunity paradigm. It designates the study of how protective enclosures acquire, and dispense, the attributes of the sacred: how a shelter becomes a sanctuary, a purifier a sacrament, a quarantine a covenant. Classical texts are cited by standard numeration; game content is identified by location and character; quotation from the games is kept to a minimum and dialogue is paraphrased.



INTRODUCTION

POLEMOS AND THE IMMUTABLE

> *War is father of all and king of all; some it reveals as gods, others as men; some it makes slaves, others free.*
>
> HERACLITUS, FR. B53 DIELS–KRANZ (MY TRANSLATION)

> *War. War never changes.*
>
> OPENING NARRATION, *FALLOUT* (1997)

> *The world was all before them, where to choose / Their place of rest, and Providence their guide.*
>
> MILTON, *PARADISE LOST* XII.646–47

I.1 TWO SENTENCES ON WAR

Two sentences about war frame this inquiry, and they contradict one another. The first is the fifty-third fragment of Heraclitus, preserved by Hippolytus, in which *polemos* is named father and king of all things. For Heraclitus war is not one event among others but the generative principle of a cosmos in perpetual flux: strife is justice, and all things come to pass through strife and necessity (B80); the ever-living fire is kindled and quenched in measures (B30); one cannot step twice into the same river (B91). War fathers change because war *is* change, the agonistic tension of opposites through which anything comes to be at all. Its genealogical power is total—it makes gods and men, slaves and free—and its sovereignty is indistinguishable from becoming.

The second sentence opens *Fallout*. Spoken by Ron Perlman at the threshold of the game, it asserts the precise inverse: war is the one thing that does not change. The monologue that follows is a compressed philosophy of history. It enumerates four regimes of war—Rome campaigning for captives and plunder, Spain raising an empire on its appetite for gold and land, Hitler remaking a ruined Germany into an industrial colossus, and the twenty-first century contending for petroleum and uranium, prizes that were also the instruments of the fighting—and after each it reaffirms that war itself is unaltered. Its account of the twenty-first century is specific about agency: China invades Alaska, the United States annexes Canada, and the European Commonwealth breaks apart into states fighting over what resources remain. The structure is Clausewitzian. In *On War* (I.1 §28), war is "more than a true chameleon," adapting its characteristics to each case, while its nature persists as the *wunderliche Dreifaltigkeit*, the wondrous trinity of primordial violence, the play of chance, and subordination to policy. The monologue stages exactly this distinction between war's mutable character and its immutable nature, and it specifies the nature in Thucydidean terms. Of the three motives the Athenians confess at Sparta—fear, honor, and interest (Thucydides I.76)—it retains only interest. Its ontology of war is materialist: war is the violent appropriation of resources, and only the resources change.

This thesis contends that the monologue's materialism is a decoy, and that the series knows it. The sentence that follows the catalogue of conquests does not name a resource. It names a refuge: a minority found shelter in vast subterranean Vaults. The history of war culminates not in a final appropriation but in an enclosure, and the Vault is war's last form—war turned inward and downward, the sovereign operation of defending an inside by negating an outside, cast in reinforced concrete and steel. The invariant the monologue cannot name is not the object fought over but the form of the fighting: the decision about who is sheltered and who is exposed, who is protected and who is expendable. War never changes because war is this decision, and the decision recurs wherever there is a door.

The catalogue's German entry shows the limit of that materialism with unusual clarity. It reduces Hitler's war to the economic revival of a defeated nation and says nothing of the extermination at its center: the murder of some six million European Jews by the Nazi state, together with Roma and Sinti, disabled people, and others it classed as unworthy of life. A list of war's motives with room for slaves, gold, territory, and oil has no room for purity. The omission is not incidental to this thesis; it is its hinge. What the monologue cannot name, the sequel stages as the Enclave's plan to kill every body that radiation has altered (Chapter 6). The war that never changes is a war over resources, but it is first a war over the boundary of the protected, and its most extreme form is the attempt to purify a population by killing the impure.

Between Heraclitus and *Fallout* lies the thesis. For Heraclitus war fathers all change. For *Fallout* war fathers nothing; it only recurs. What changes in the wasteland is not war but its remainder: the irradiated, the exiled, the contaminated, the mutant. The Latin is exact. *Mutare* means to change; the mutant is the one who has been changed. The slogan, read as a definition rather than a lament, names the series' antagonist—the immutable—and thereby nominates its protagonist: the mutable. Every major sovereignty in the diptych is an attempt to master time by abolishing change, and every decisive victory belongs to someone whom change has already marked.

I.2 FALLOUT, NOT APOCALYPSE

The title is itself a philosophical claim. The series might have called its catastrophe an apocalypse; it calls it a fallout. *Apokalypsis* names an unveiling, the disclosure at the end of time in which history is judged and closed. Fallout names what descends after the event: radioactive particulate, the residue that rains back down from the column of the explosion and lingers in soil, water, and flesh. Where apocalypse is a terminus, fallout is a remainder.

The word has a history, and the history has authors. The only nuclear weapons ever used against people were dropped by the United States on Hiroshima and Nagasaki on 6 and 9 August 1945, killing an estimated 150,000 to 246,000 people by the end of that year, the great majority of them civilians. "Fallout" entered everyday speech nine years

later. On 1 March 1954 the United States detonated the Castle Bravo thermonuclear device at Bikini Atoll; its yield, some fifteen megatons, far exceeded prediction, and its fallout descended on the inhabitants of Rongelap and Utirik, who were evacuated only after two to three days of exposure, and on the crew of the Japanese fishing boat *Daigo Fukuryū Maru*, the *Lucky Dragon No. 5*, whose radio operator, Kuboyama Aikichi, died that September. The Atomic Energy Commission enrolled the exposed Marshallese in a long-term study of radiation's effects on human beings, Project 4.1, having judged within days of the test that the islanders' responses could be of great medical and military value, and in 1957 returned the Rongelap community to its still-contaminated atoll, where the monitoring continued until 1985, when the islanders asked Greenpeace to evacuate them and it did. Months after Bravo, Ishirō Honda's *Gojira* (1954) opened with a Japanese freighter, the Eiko-maru, destroyed at sea in a blinding flash, a scene widely read as a reference to the Lucky Dragon. The title therefore names not an abstraction but a documented harm, inflicted by a state on populations it treated as expendable and followed by the conversion of the exposed into subjects of observation. That conversion is the template of Vault 12.

Jacques Derrida's "No Apocalypse, Not Now" (1984), written for the special issue of *Diacritics* that inaugurated nuclear criticism, argued that total nuclear war is "fabulously textual": an event that has never occurred, that exists only as discourse, and whose hypothesis is the remainderless destruction of the archive, including the literature that might have mourned it. *Fallout* begins after precisely such a war, yet the war is not its subject. Its subject is everything the hypothesis excludes. Archives survive as holodisks and terminal records; institutions survive as experiments that continue to run long after their designers are dead; ideologies survive in the Enclave's claim to be the United States; memory survives in the ghouls, whose irradiated longevity makes them living witnesses to the world before. *Fallout* is a poetics of the remainder.

The word carries two further senses the games exploit. A falling-out is an estrangement, the rupture of a bond; the Fall is the lapsarian event of Genesis, the expulsion from the garden. The diptych braids all three senses—physical residue, social rupture, theological expulsion. *Fallout* ends with a falling-out between the Vault Dweller and Vault 13, staged as an expulsion; *Fallout 2* is a quest for the Garden of Eden packed in a case. The braid yields the thesis's governing term. The *Exsultet* of the Easter Vigil praises the sin of Adam as a happy fault—*O felix culpa*—because it merited so great a Redeemer; Augustine had judged it better that God bring good out of evil than permit no evil at all (*Enchiridion* 27); Milton's Adam, shown the future, marvels that so much good should be produced from evil (*Paradise Lost* XII.469–71). *Fallout* secularizes the paradox while stripping it of its redeemer. Contamination is fortunate here not because it occasions salvation but because it forecloses purity, the most lethal fantasy shared by the pre-war state and all of its posthumous heirs. I call this structure *felix contaminatio*.

I.3 THE STATE OF THE QUESTION

Fallout occupies a secure place in the canon of computer role-playing games, yet its philosophical content remains underexamined. Critical attention has gravitated toward the Bethesda-era sequels, with their monumentalized retro-futurism, nostalgic soundscapes, and explorable ruins, and toward the factional politics of *New Vegas*. The Interplay-era games are typically treated as origins—reservoirs of iconography, mechanics, and lore—rather than as arguments in their own right. Developer retrospectives, Tim Cain's extensive video commentaries since 2023 prominent among them, illuminate production history but do not, and need not, supply a philosophical reading. This thesis treats the diptych as a complete philosophical statement and claims for it a coherence that exceeds any declared intention.

Two contexts sharpen the claim. The first is disciplinary. *Fallout* appeared in 1997, the year of Espen Aarseth's *Cybertext*, Janet Murray's *Hamlet on the Holodeck*, and Brian Sutton-Smith's *The Ambiguity of Play*, founding texts of game studies that theorized ergodic effort, agency and transformation, and the rhetorics of play. *Fallout* theorizes all three in practice, with a philosophical ambition the young discipline had not yet learned to recognize in its objects.

The second context is historical. *Fallout* returned to nuclear apocalypse at the moment it seemed obsolete. Francis Fukuyama's "The End of History?" (1989) and *The End of History and the Last Man* (1992) had declared the ideological evolution of humanity complete; Derrida's *Specters of Marx* (1993) answered that the declared end was haunted by everything it claimed to bury. In 1992 the *Washington Post Magazine* exposed the congressional bunker beneath the Greenbrier resort, a relic of the secret architecture by which the American state had planned to outlive its citizens. *Fallout* belongs to this conjuncture. It is a specter of the Cold War summoned after the Cold War's burial, and its refrain refutes the end of history directly: history continues after the end of the world, because the logics that ended it survive.

I.4 THE THESIS

The argument is advanced as six propositions.

01 **The paradigmatic devices.** The diptych organizes its political theology around three devices. The Vault is the architecture of sovereignty as immunity; the Vat is the sacrament of sovereignty as unity; the Garden is the commodified instrument of re-creation, whose ethical valence the games leave undecided.

02 **Anti-natal sovereignty.** The series' three great sovereign powers—Vault-Tec's Overseers, the Master, and the Enclave—share a single structure: each attempts to master time by abolishing birth. The Vault arrests time; the Vat replaces generation with fabrication and issues in sterility; the Enclave would exterminate the im-

pure majority. Within the wasteland's polities, slavery reproduces the structure as what Orlando Patterson calls natal alienation.

03 **The definition of war.** "War never changes" defines war, and the sovereignty that wages it, as the immutable. The mutant, etymologically the changed, is the bearer of history.

04 **Exilic natality.** The protagonists acquire the power to begin through exposure. The Vault Dweller, exiled for having changed, founds a people; the Chosen One, born of that exile and classified as a mutant, destroys the last sovereign and plants a garden.

05 **Felix contaminatio.** Contamination, not purity, is the condition of a livable future, and the series' ethical emblem is the door that would not close.

06 **The ludic enactment.** The games' form—nonlinear, ergodic, generically impure, measured by an attribute schema that democratizes the "special"—is the procedural enactment of the argument their content makes.

Table 1 sets the paradigms side by side.

TABLE 1 · THE PARADIGMS SIDE BY SIDE

PARADIGM	DEVICE AND SITE	SOVEREIGN FIGURE	ANTI-NATAL OPERATION	PRINCIPAL LINEAGE	UNDONE BY
Vault	Sealed vault: Vault 13, Vault City, the Brotherhood's bunker	The Overseer	Stasis: time arrested, the changed expelled	Plato, Bentham, Weber, Esposito	The exile who founds Arroyo
Vat	FEV vats at Mariposa; the Cathedral	The Master	Fabrication in place of birth; sterility	Rousseau, Hegel, Nietzsche, Kojève	Logos: the proof of sterility
Purity	Curling-13; the Poseidon oil platform	The Enclave's President	Extermination of the impure majority	Schmitt, Foucault, Agamben, Mbembe	The "mutant" Chosen One
Garden	The G.E.C.K.	None, or anyone	Undecided: Vault City or a new Arroyo	Genesis, Milton, Voltaire, Haraway	Planting by the expelled and the abducted together

I.5 ARCHITECTURE OF THE ARGUMENT

The thesis proceeds in four parts. Part I, *The Vault*, opens with the historical and aesthetic conditions of the series' retro-futurism (Chapter 1), reading the games through Koselleck's futures past, the pedagogy of Cold War civil defense, and the ethics of the shelter doorway, before constructing the Vault paradigm proper (Chapter 2) through Esposito, Plato's cave, Forster's "The Machine Stops," and the immunological logic of the Vault Dweller's exile. Part II, *The Vat*, reconstructs the Master's philosophy of Unity and its defeat by argument (Chapter 3), then follows the sacralization of technology in the Brotherhood of Steel and its archive (Chapter 4). Part III, *The Polis*, traces the genealogy of the wasteland state from Junktown's rival sovereigns to the New California Republic, through the political economy of water, the market of vice, and the citizenship regime of Vault City (Chapter 5), and then confronts the Enclave as the autoimmune terminus of American sovereignty (Chapter 6). Part IV, *The Garden*, reads the G.E.C.K. against the American pastoral, the theology of the fortunate fall, and the tradition of the ingénu (Chapter 7), and analyzes the games' procedural systems as an ethics of mutability (Chapter 8). The Conclusion assembles the concept of *felix contaminatio* and tests it against the speculative tradition and against the games' own complicities.



CHAPTER 1

FUTURES PAST

Retrofuturism, Civil Defense, and the Nuclear Uncanny

THE WASTELAND OF *Fallout* is set not in the future but in a future that has already been: the horizon of expectation of mid-century America, actualized, inhabited, and destroyed. This chapter argues that the series' celebrated retro-futurism is not nostalgia but nostalgia's autopsy—an aesthetic that exhumes the Atomic Age's image of tomorrow in order to display the wound through which it died. Its method is historical before it is philosophical: the games' visual and acoustic idiom is a sustained citation of Cold War civil defense, and the citation is critical.

1.1 THE TENSE OF THE WASTELAND

Reinhart Koselleck's *Futures Past* (1979) describes modernity as the progressive divergence of two historical categories: the *space of experience*, the past made present in memory and habit, and the *horizon of expectation*, the future made present in hope, fear, and planning. Modern time is the widening of the gap between them, the expectation that tomorrow will not resemble yesterday. *Fallout* closes the gap backward. The expectation of 1955 becomes the experience of 2077 and, by 2161, the object of archaeology. Its grammatical tense is the future anterior—what *will have been*—and its world is a counterfactual in which the mid-century imagination of the future simply became the future: vacuum-tube computing, chrome automata, atomic automobiles, streamlined appliances, a wrist-mounted Pip-Boy whose interface is a phosphor screen in a bakelite housing. Leonard Boyarsky's art direction does not decorate the twenty-second century with antiques; it renders a history in which the antiques won.

Fredric Jameson's account of postmodern pastiche supplies the necessary contrast. The "nostalgia mode" of *Postmodernism, or, The Cultural Logic of Late Capitalism* (1991) reproduces the glossy surfaces of a past decade in order to evade history, substituting a stylistic connotation of pastness for any genuine historical relation. *Fallout* reproduces the same surfaces in order to crack them. Every chrome curve is pitted, every cheerful billboard bleached, every jingle broadcast over a crater. The style is placed under the sign of its consequence, so that the period's confidence becomes legible as the period's guilt. Jean Baudrillard's third-order simulacrum—a copy without an original—fits the series' 1950s, which never existed as depicted; but the series stages the *ruin* of a simulacrum, the moment at which the precession of images ends not in hyperreality but in fallout.

The late 1990s experienced its own canceled future. Mark Fisher, borrowing Franco Berardi's phrase, would later diagnose the "slow cancellation of the future" and call the art that registers it hauntological, after Derrida's *Specters of Marx* (1993). *Fallout* is hauntological before the term's popularization, with an inversion that matters: its specters come not from the past but from the future. The wasteland is haunted by tomorrow—by the robots still patrolling, the advertisements still promising, the Vault doors still awaiting a population that will emerge into the world the brochures described. Even the Fukuyaman end of history appears in the series as an architectural

program. Vault 13, as the sequel discloses, was designed to remain sealed for two centuries: a laboratory of the post-historical, a sealed present in which nothing is meant to happen. The narrative begins when the end of history breaks down—when a single component, the water chip, fails.

1.2 THE PEDAGOGY OF CATASTROPHE

The American state taught its citizens to imagine survival through an apparatus of instruction that *Fallout* reproduces almost item for item. The Federal Civil Defense Administration, created in 1950, sponsored the film *Duck and Cover* (1951), in which Bert the Turtle demonstrated to schoolchildren that the correct posture could defeat an atomic flash. In Operation Doorstep (1953), the agency built furnished houses at the Nevada Test Site, populated them with mannequin families, exposed them to a nuclear detonation, and circulated the results in photographs and film. Joseph Masco has called this practice the engineering of ruins: the state rehearsed its own destruction to manufacture a disciplined affect, and in doing so produced what he names the *nuclear uncanny*—the domestic interior made strange by the anticipation of its annihilation.

The *Fallout* wasteland is Operation Doorstep's afterlife. Its interiors are mannequin homes after the blast, furnished with the debris of a consumer society arrested midgesture. Its mascot is Bert the Turtle's heir. The grinning, thumbs-up Vault Boy who illustrates the manuals, perks, and traits teaches the player catastrophe in the idiom of the safety pamphlet, smiling while he is dismembered, irradiated, or reduced to ash. Tracy C. Davis has shown that civil defense was fundamentally performance—drills, exercises, and rehearsals in which citizens played survivors of a war that had not happened. *Fallout* is the performance's final act, staged after the curtain has burned.

Paul Boyer and Spencer Weart document the atom's double image in postwar culture: utopian and apocalyptic, the clean energy of Eisenhower's "Atoms for Peace" (1953) and Lewis Strauss's electricity "too cheap to meter" (1954), alongside the mushroom cloud and the irradiated monster. *Fallout*'s world actualizes the utopian atom—fusion-powered cars, micro-fusion cells, nuclear domesticity—and discovers it to be identical with the apocalyptic one. The utopian and the apocalyptic atom are one atom; the series refuses the comfortable division by which postwar culture kept them apart.

The openings make the refusal audible. *Fallout* begins with the Ink Spots' "Maybe" (1940) playing over a Vault-Tec commercial and a newsreel in which American soldiers in power armor shoot a kneeling, unarmed man and then wave to the camera; *Fallout 2* opens to Louis Armstrong's "A Kiss to Build a Dream On" (1951). The juxtaposition dramatizes the thesis of Horkheimer and Adorno's *Dialectic of Enlightenment* (1944/1947) that the culture industry's amusements are continuous with the domination they appear to suspend. The song's tenderness is the newsreel's anesthetic. The montage does

not merely contrast sentiment with atrocity; it exposes their complicity, the way a culture's sweetest dreams of the future were soundtracked over its executions.

1.3 ETHICS AT THE SHELTER DOORWAY

In his address on the Berlin crisis of 25 July 1961, John F. Kennedy urged Americans to prepare fallout shelters, and the ensuing shelter boom produced the most explicit public debate the United States ever conducted on the morality of exclusion. In "Ethics at the Shelter Doorway," published in the Jesuit weekly *America* that autumn, L. C. McHugh defended the right of a shelter owner to repel neighbors, by lethal force if necessary, when they sought entry. The press dubbed the controversy "gun thy neighbor." Rod Serling's *Twilight Zone* episode "The Shelter" (1961) dramatized it as a suburban dinner party that disintegrates into savagery when a false alarm reveals that only one family has a shelter; the neighbors batter down its door, the alarm is withdrawn, and the moral damage remains. Kenneth Rose's *One Nation Underground* (2001) shows that most Americans never built shelters at all, out of skepticism, expense, and a moral revulsion that the doorway debate made articulate.

Fallout institutionalizes the doorway. Salvation is allocated by Vault-Tec, a corporation under government contract, through reservation and selection; the shelter owner's private ethics are privatized at continental scale and sold. The door becomes the series' supreme moral threshold. The first image after character creation is a cog-shaped vault door; the last image of *Fallout* is the same door closing on the one who saved the Vault. The diptych opens and closes at the shelter doorway, and its question is McHugh's: who has the right to be inside? Across both games the answer is that the right to be inside is the original form of war.

1.4 KAHN'S QUESTION AND THE MINESHAFT GAP

Herman Kahn's *On Thermonuclear War* (1960) posed the question that defined the strategic imagination of the era: would the survivors envy the dead? Kahn answered no. He distinguished among "tragic but distinguishable postwar states," modeled economic recovery, and insisted that nuclear war, however terrible, would not end history. *Fallout* accepts Kahn's answer and reverses its valence. The survivors do not envy the dead; they rebuild precisely the institutions—markets, militaries, eugenic sciences, sovereign enclaves—that killed them. The horror is not envy but recurrence.

Stanley Kubrick's *Dr. Strangelove* (1964), whose strategist owes much to Kahn, proposed the series' governing image a generation early. Strangelove's plan to shelter a computer-selected nucleus of humanity at the bottom of mineshafts for a century, chosen for youth, health, fertility, intelligence, and useful skills, with women outnumbering men, provokes the generals' anxiety about a "mineshaft gap." The Vaults realize the mineshaft with one decisive twist: they are not arks but experiments, and the eugenic

selection Strangelove proposed in earnest becomes, in Vault-Tec's hands, social science conducted on unknowing subjects. Behind the satire stood a real architecture. Programs for the continuity of government built bunkers at Mount Weather and Raven Rock, and the congressional shelter beneath the Greenbrier resort, exposed by Ted Gup in 1992, revealed how concretely the state had planned to survive its citizens. The Enclave of *Fallout 2* is this architecture's posthumous child.

Günther Anders, the philosopher of the bomb, identified in *Die Antiquiertheit des Menschen* (1956) a "Promethean gap" between what humanity can produce and what it can imagine: the bomb exceeds the capacity of feeling, and this deficit produces a blindness to apocalypse. Karl Jaspers, in *The Atom Bomb and the Future of Man* (1958), demanded a conversion of political thinking equal to the new weapon. *Fallout* operates on the gap from both sides. It makes the unimaginable navigable, converting catastrophe into a map, an inventory, and a quest log; and it risks the familiarization Anders feared, in which catastrophe becomes a playground. Its black humor is at once the defense against apocalypse-blindness and one of its symptoms, and the thesis returns to this ambivalence in Chapter 8.

1.5 THE RUIN AS EMBLEM

Walter Benjamin's *Origin of the German Trauerspiel* (1928) holds that allegories are, in the realm of thought, what ruins are in the realm of things. The allegorist contemplates the world as fragment and as emblem, and the Baroque emblem book—since Andrea Alciato's *Emblematum liber* (1531)—fuses an image with a motto and an explanatory gloss. *Fallout*'s formal apparatus is emblematic in this strict sense. The isometric camera assumes the elevated, oblique gaze of the melancholic who looks down upon the ruin as a sign. The epilogue of each game is a sequence of painted tableaux, each devoted to one settlement and glossed by a narrator who pronounces its fate. The epilogue is an emblem book of the wasteland: image, title, judgment.

Benjamin's ninth thesis on the philosophy of history (1940) describes the angel of history, face turned toward the past, seeing a single catastrophe that piles wreckage upon wreckage where human beings perceive a chain of events, while the storm called progress drives him backward into a future he cannot see. The Vault Dweller crossing the Boneyard, the ruin of Los Angeles, occupies this posture with uncanny fidelity. The traversal of the map is a backward progress through debris, and the ruins compose one catastrophe rather than a sequence: the same war, by the monologue's definition, recurring. The seventh thesis—that there is no document of civilization which is not at the same time a document of barbarism—will find its exact illustration in Vault City.

Retro-futurism thus performs a precise political function. It historicizes the future, revealing a culture's image of tomorrow as an ideology with a date, an iconography, and a body count. The Vault is that ideology's architecture, and the next chapter enters it.



CHAPTER 2

THE VAULT PARADIGM

Immunity, the Cave, and the Vaccine Who Must Be Expelled

THE VAULT IS THE series' master architecture of sovereignty: a shelter that is also a laboratory, a sanctuary that is also a cage, and a community that preserves itself by expelling whoever has been exposed. This chapter constructs the Vault paradigm in five movements—immunity, the parable of the failing machine, the allegory of the cave, the vaccine, and the paradox that binds them—and argues that the ending of *Fallout* is the most exact dramatization of the immunitary logic in the speculative canon.

2.1 THE ARCHITECTURE OF IMMUNITY

Roberto Esposito's trilogy—*Communitas* (1998), *Immunitas* (2002), and *Bios* (2004)—reconstructs community from the Latin *munus*, a gift that is also an office and an obligation. The members of a *communitas* are bound not by a shared property but by a shared debt, a common exposure to what they owe one another. The *immunis* is the one exempted from the *munus*, dispensed from the common burden. Modernity, on Esposito's account, is the progressive immunization of life: sovereignty, property, and liberty are devices that protect individual existence from the risks of community. Yet immunization protects life by negating it. Like a vaccine, it introduces into the body a fragment of what it fights, and pushed to its limit it turns against the life it was meant to preserve.

The Vault is *immunitas* cast in concrete. Its residents are exempted from the *munus* of the surface, the common exposure to the war's consequences; its cog-shaped door is the machine of exemption, rolling aside to admit the protected and rolling back to exclude the rest. The Vault promises exactly what the immunitary paradigm promises—life preserved through separation—and delivers exactly what the paradigm delivers: a preserved life that cannot live.

The sequel and its paratexts complete the picture: the Vaults were experiments, and their authors can be named. Vault-Tec built and ran them under contract to the pre-war federal government, and the series' paratexts attribute the program to that government—whose surviving apparatus the sequel calls the Enclave. The *Fallout Bible* gives the experiments' real purpose as the study of how pre-selected populations bear isolation and how well they recolonize once the doors open, and Tim Cain has since explained the design intent behind it: the Enclave wanted data for a starship that would carry a chosen few to another world. Vault 8, a control vault, opened on schedule, and its residents founded Vault City. Vault-Tec engineered Vault 12's door never to seal, deliberately exposing its residents to radiation; they became the ghouls of Necropolis. Vault 13 was meant to remain closed for two centuries as a study in prolonged isolation. Vault 15 mixed residents of radically opposed ideologies for a planned fifty years; overcrowded and split by schism, it opened early, and by the later lore its survivors founded Shady Sands with the vault's own G.E.C.K. while others formed the raider bands of the Khans, the Jackals, and the Vipers. The shelter was the laboratory and the protected were the subjects; on the paratexts' account, the sovereign that designed the

experiment is the sovereign that returns in the sequel to harvest Vault 13. Protection and observation are not two functions of the Vault but one function seen from two sides.

The office that governs the Vault condenses three genealogies of power. The Overseer is, first, a panoptic function. Jeremy Bentham's *Panopticon* (1791), read by Foucault in *Discipline and Punish* (1975) as the diagram of disciplinary society, renders visibility a trap: a population that may always be watched learns to watch itself. Vault 13's residents wear numbered, uniform jumpsuits and live under a single office that sees and records. The Overseer is, second, a pastor: the English word renders the Greek *episkopos*, the overseer who became the bishop, and the Vault's Overseer exercises what Foucault called pastoral power, the shepherd's individualizing care for each and all, *omnes et singulatim*. The Overseer is, third, a plantation office: in American usage the overseer is the man who drives enslaved labor in the field. Surveillance, pastorate, and the discipline of labor are fused in one title, and Max Weber's *stahlhartes Gehäuse* (1905)—the "iron cage" of rationalized modernity in Talcott Parsons's rendering—becomes, in the Vault, a shell of steel one may literally inhabit.

The Vault has real precedents in twentieth-century science, and they can be named precisely. John B. Calhoun's rodent utopias, culminating in "Universe 25" (1968–1972), provided an enclosure with unlimited food and water and no predators; the population flourished, then collapsed into the social pathology Calhoun had named the "behavioral sink" and finally into extinction—an immunized utopia that dies of its immunity. Biosphere 2 sealed eight people inside an Arizona ecological enclosure from 1991 to 1993; oxygen levels fell, food ran short, and the crew split into factions. It ended as *Fallout* entered development, the nearest real-world analogue to a sealed world whose life-support fails. The experiments on human beings have named authors. From 1932 to 1972 the United States Public Health Service observed untreated syphilis in 399 Black men in Macon County, Alabama, alongside 201 uninfected controls, telling them they were being treated for "bad blood" and offering free medical examinations, meals, and burial insurance while withholding penicillin after it became the treatment of choice in the 1940s; the study ended in 1972, after Peter Buxtun, a Public Health Service employee, leaked it to Jean Heller of the Associated Press. Stanley Milgram's obedience experiments, begun at Yale in 1961, months after Adolf Eichmann's trial opened in Jerusalem, and published in 1963, deceived participants into believing they were inflicting painful electric shocks on another person. Participants in the Stanford Prison Experiment of 1971 knew they were taking part in a study, but later archival work found that the experimenters instructed the guards how to behave and led them to believe they were not themselves subjects, findings Zimbardo disputed. Tuskegee is the Vault's closest structural analogue: its subjects believed themselves treated as the Vault's believe themselves sheltered, care was the experiment's disguise, and the population chosen for observation was chosen by race and poverty—the biopolitical cut that Chapter 6 follows to the Enclave.

Giorgio Agamben argued in *Homo Sacer* (1995) that the camp, the space opened when the state of exception becomes the rule, is the hidden paradigm of modern politics. The Vault is a camp of a peculiar kind: one whose inmates believe themselves to be the saved. Philip K. Dick's *The Penultimate Truth* (1964) supplies the structure in fiction, imagining underground workers who manufacture robots for a war their rulers falsely tell them still rages on the surface. Dick's ant tanks and Vault-Tec's vaults share the same architecture of deception: the shelter is a lie about the outside, and the lie is the shelter's purpose.

2.2 THE MACHINE STOPS

E. M. Forster's "The Machine Stops" (1909) is the Vault paradigm's earliest complete statement. Humanity lives underground in identical cells, every need met by the Machine; direct experience is distrusted and the *Book of the Machine* is scripture. Kuno, who reaches the surface without permission, is threatened with Homelessness—expulsion to the surface, understood as death. The Machine's mending apparatus fails, the Machine stops, and civilization dies in the dark. Yet Kuno has glimpsed people living on the surface: the Homeless survive.

Fallout transposes Forster's plot almost point for point. The Vault's mending apparatus, the water chip, fails. Survival requires the forbidden act of going outside. The punishment for having gone outside is Homelessness. The surface is inhabited. The difference is the twist of the knife: Forster's transgressor cannot save the Machine, while *Fallout*'s transgressor saves it and is made homeless anyway. Forster wrote a parable of technological dependence; *Fallout* rewrites it as a parable of immunitary ingratitude, in which the community's debt to the one who saved it is discharged by expelling them.

Harlan Ellison's novella "A Boy and His Dog" (1969), filmed by L. Q. Jones in 1975, is the series' most direct cinematic ancestor and its sharpest conceptual anticipation. Beneath the irradiated surface lies Topeka, a "downunder" community preserving a grotesque simulacrum of small-town Americana—painted faces, marching bands, church socials—governed by a committee that eliminates nonconformists. Its men are sterile, so the surface scavenger Vic is lured below to father children on its women. The underground's continuity depends on the contaminated vitality of the surface it despises. *Fallout* inherits from Ellison the dog companion, the deadpan cruelty, and the fauxmid-century underground; it inherits above all the insight that the sealed community needs the outside it excludes. That insight returns, magnified, when the Master and the Enclave each seek the Vaults' unexposed bodies as raw material.

2.3 THE ALLEGORY OF THE VAULT

In *Republic* VII (514a–517a) Plato imagines prisoners chained in a cave, taking the shadows cast on its wall for reality. One is freed, dragged up the steep ascent into the sun, painfully dazzled, and only gradually able to see. When he returns to tell the others, they mock him, and Socrates adds that if they could lay hands on the man who tried to free them, they would kill him (517a).

Fallout enacts the allegory with literal fidelity. The entrance to Vault 13 opens into a cave, and the Vault Dweller's first steps outside are a passage through that cave into the glare of the wasteland. The return fulfills Socrates' prophecy with bureaucratic courtesy. The Overseer does not kill the returnee; he exiles them, explaining that they have changed, that their stories of the outside would lure the Vault's young away, and that the Vault's survival requires its closure. The Vault's founding myth is a Platonic noble lie (*Republic* III 414b–415d): not the myth of the metals but the myth of shelter itself, the claim that the Vault exists to protect rather than to observe.

The series nonetheless inverts Plato's metaphysics. In the *Republic* the sun is the image of the Good, the source of being and intelligibility. In *Fallout* the outside is radiation and mutation; the sun that dazzles the emergent dweller is the sun that reveals the irradiated ruin. The philosopher returns contaminated—literally exposed—and the contamination is the truth they carry. The result is a contaminated Platonism. Knowledge is not contemplation from a purified height but contact: the truth of the world cannot be seen from a sealed interior, and to know it is to be touched by it. The ascent leads not to the Form of the Good but, in the Brotherhood's initiation, to the Glow.

2.4 THE VACCINE WHO MUST BE EXPELLED

Esposito's paradigmatic figure of immunization is vaccination: the deliberate introduction of a controlled dose of the pathogen to provoke the body's defenses. The Vault Dweller is the Vault's vaccine. A portion of the community is deliberately exposed to the outside so that the inside may be secured; once the antibody—the water chip—has been produced, the antigen must be cleared. The Overseer's decree is not a betrayal of the quest but its immunological completion.

Derrida's "Plato's Pharmacy" (1968) traces the Platonic *pharmakon*—remedy and poison at once—to its unspoken cousin, the *pharmakos*, the scapegoat expelled from Athens at the Thargelia to purify the city. The water chip is the *pharmakon*, the purifier whose absence poisons; the Vault Dweller is the *pharmakos*, sent out to fetch the remedy and sent out again once it is delivered. Derrida observes that the word *pharmakos* never appears in Plato's text; the Vault, likewise, never names its exile as sacrifice. It calls the expulsion gratitude.

René Girard's *Violence and the Sacred* (1972) and *The Scapegoat* (1982) describe communities that resolve mimetic crisis through the unanimous expulsion of a victim, who

is afterward sacralized as the origin of the restored order. *Fallout 2* completes the Girardian cycle with precision. The expelled Vault Dweller becomes the founding ancestor of the tribe of Arroyo, revered in its legends; the Vault jumpsuit becomes a relic passed to the Chosen One; the scapegoat becomes the god. Agamben's *homo sacer*, who may be killed but not sacrificed because they stand outside both human and divine law, names the exile's legal condition, and the wasteland names the space of bare life in which the exile must now live.

Ursula K. Le Guin's "The Ones Who Walk Away from Omelas" (1973) describes a city whose joy depends on the misery of a single child, and the few who, learning this, walk away. In *Fallout*, walking away is imposed rather than chosen, and the one who walks away founds a new city: Omelas inverted into foundation. Heidegger's "Building Dwelling Thinking" (1951) defines dwelling as being at peace in a preserved place within the fourfold of earth, sky, divinities, and mortals. The Vault is a dwelling without sky or gods, in which mortals are hidden from their mortality—a dwelling against dwelling. The protagonist bears the title "Vault Dweller" only after ceasing to dwell there, and enters the condition the "Letter on Humanism" calls *Heimatlosigkeit*, homelessness as the destiny of the world. Heidegger joined the National Socialist party on 1 May 1933, ten days after becoming rector at Freiburg, and remained a member until 1945; his Black Notebooks, published from 2014, contain antisemitic passages, and how far the commitment shaped his thought of rootedness remains disputed. The series inverts him regardless, making homelessness the condition of founding rather than its loss.

Milton's expulsion, finally, supplies the ending's form. *Paradise Lost* closes as Adam and Eve, hand in hand, take their solitary way out of Eden with the world all before them. The final cinematic of *Fallout* is a Miltonic expulsion in which Providence is replaced by the open structure of the role-playing game: the "where to choose" is the player's. A variant of the closing sequence, triggered by bad karma or simply by having chosen the Bloody Mess trait at character creation, has the exile shoot the Overseer before departing—the scapegoat's revenge, the vaccine turning on the body that administered it, and, in the Bloody Mess case, an appetite for spectacle chosen at the outset deciding how the story ends (Chapter 8.6).

2.5 THE OVERSEER'S PARADOX

The chapter's argument can be formalized. *An immunitary community can survive only by exposing a part of itself, and can remain immune only by expelling the part it has exposed.* I call this the Overseer's Paradox, and every Vault in the diptych is a variation on it.

Vault 8 opens as designed and immediately reconstitutes its wall as citizenship, founding the gated technocracy of Vault City. Vault 12, whose door would not close, yields the ghouls—the exposed who, against every expectation, outlive their sealed contemporaries. Vault 13's isolation ends in the sequel with the Enclave's abduction of its residents: the sealed are the purest specimens and therefore the most valuable prey, so

that perfect immunity becomes perfect vulnerability to sovereign capture. Vault 15's heterogeneity dissolves into a republic and a raider band. The paradox extends beyond Vault-Tec's inventory: the Brotherhood of Steel's bunker, closed to outsiders, guards its knowledge and dwindles; the Enclave's oil platform is a vault set on the sea.

The paradox is encoded procedurally as well as narratively. In *Fallout*'s economy of risk, the water caravans the Hub's Water Merchants will send to slake the Vault's thirst add a hundred days to the search for the chip but, by revealing where the Vault lies, took a hundred days off the Master's march on it in the game as first released; a patch soon stretched that second deadline to thirteen years and quietly removed the cost. As first designed, relief is purchased by exposure; every reprieve opens the door a crack.

The paradox has a corollary that governs the remainder of the thesis. The immunitary community cannot produce novelty from within; whatever is new arrives from the exposed. Natality is exogenous to the Vault. Vault 13's future is not its sealed population, which the Enclave will harvest, but the descendants of its exile. This is the first principle of the series' political theology: *exilic natality*, the capacity to begin that belongs to those who have been cast out.



CHAPTER 3

THE VAT

The Master's Unity, Forced Evolution, and the Sterility of the Absolute

THE MASTER IS THE series' most philosophically serious antagonist because his project is not domination but reconciliation: the end of human division through the fabrication of a single species. This chapter reads the Forced Evolutionary Virus as the hinge of the series' immunological plot, the vat as a counterfeit sacrament, and the Master's defeat by argument as a tragic recognition in which the logic of unity collides with the fact of birth.

3.1 FROM PAN-IMMUNITY TO FORCED EVOLUTION

The genealogy of the Forced Evolutionary Virus can be reconstructed from the research records the Vault Dweller may recover in the irradiated ruin of the West Tek facility, the Glow, and at the Mariposa Military Base. The virus originates in a United States government program against biological warfare, a "Pan-Immunity Virion Project" carried out by the contractor West Tek and intended to render the human body resistant to every disease. Experiment reveals it instead as a mutagen that enlarges and strengthens its hosts and, in some subjects, augments intelligence. The United States Army then takes the program over and moves it to Mariposa, where its scientists test the virus on human beings—military prisoners, by the account the Brotherhood preserves—by immersing them in it. The successive names register a conceptual drift from immunity to evolution: from the protection of a given body to the production of a new one, from defense to transformation.

This drift is the spine of what I call the series' immunological plot. Pan-immunity yields forced evolution; forced evolution yields the super mutant; and the sequel's Enclave will refine the same virus into Curling-13, a weapon of purification. The diptych's biological arc is a single conceptual sequence in which the project of protecting life is carried to the point of abolishing it. The super mutant is the perfectly immunized body: vast, radiation-hardened, preternaturally durable—and sterile. The perfectly protected body is a body without a future. Esposito's thesis, pressed to its limit, finds its emblem here: immunity's negation of life completes itself as the negation of generation.

A further detail binds the Vat to the Vault. The Master learns that the virus performs poorly on bodies already damaged by radiation, which yield duller mutants, and he therefore covets the unexposed—Vault dwellers. The architecture of immunity supplies the raw material for the biology of unity. The Vault Dweller's quest is shadowed from the start by the fact that the quester is precisely what the enemy requires.

3.2 MARIPOSA: THE BUTTERFLY BASE

Mariposa is Spanish for butterfly. The site of forced metamorphosis bears the name of the archetype of natural metamorphosis, and the irony runs deep. In Greek, *psychē* names both the soul and the butterfly; the larva's passage into winged life was an ancient image of the soul's liberation, allegorized in Apuleius's tale of Cupid and Psyche. Mariposa performs a metamorphosis without psyche, a transformation of the body that leaves the soul diminished, captive, or erased. Ovid's *Metamorphoses* catalogues changes of form as divine punishments and mercies; Kafka's *Die Verwandlung* (1915) shows metamorphosis producing not a new being but social death, as Gregor Samsa, no longer productive and no longer bearable, dies of his family's neglect. The super mutant is Gregor militarized: a transformed body whose severed social bonds are replaced by an army.

Mariposa also gives birth to the Brotherhood of Steel, and the birth is violent. In October 2077, by the account preserved in the Brotherhood's records, Captain Roger Maxson and his soldiers discovered that the West Tek scientists were using military prisoners as unwilling test subjects. The base's commander, Colonel Robert Spindel, broke down and killed himself; Maxson interrogated the chief scientist, Robert Anderson, and executed him, and the interrogations of the other scientists ended the same way. Maxson buried the dead outside the base, seceded from the United States Army on the eve of the war, and led his men and their families to the bunker at Lost Hills. The super mutants and the Brotherhood are twins born of the same vats, one by immersion and the other by revulsion—but the revulsion founded its order with summary executions, a sovereign decision on the exception taken before the bombs fell. The two great postwar powers of the first game descend from a single crime and from the two possible responses to it: fusion and enclosure, assimilation and secession. Unity and immunity share a birthplace, and the butterfly base is their common womb.

3.3 THE VAT AS SACRAMENT

Above the Master's lair stands a cathedral. The Children of the Cathedral, the Master's religious front, preach unity, operate healing missions in the Hub, and recruit. The architecture is theological: church above, vault below, and at Mariposa the vats—a sacramental factory. Immersion in the virus is a counterfeit baptism. Christian baptism by immersion is a burial and a resurrection, a descent into death so that the baptized may walk in newness of life (Romans 6:3–4), and a second birth of water and spirit without which none may see the kingdom (John 3:3–7). The vat performs regeneration without generation. The dipped are reborn into a body that cannot itself give birth. The sacrament of the vat inverts the sacrament of the font: born again, so as never to bear.

The Cathedral's high priest is named Morpheus, after the god of dreams whom Ovid places in the house of Sleep (*Metamorphoses* XI) and from whom Friedrich Sertürner, in

the early nineteenth century, named morphine. The Master's church is led by the eponym of the narcotic the young Marx invoked when he called religion the opium of the people (1843–44). The Children's healing missions—medicine as recruitment—enact Nietzsche's portrait of the ascetic priest in the third essay of *On the Genealogy of Morality* (1887), who rules the suffering by administering their suffering and converts sickness into allegiance. In Weber's typology, the Master's authority is charismatic, and the Cathedral is its routinization: charisma become church, vision become institution.

Franklin J. Schaffner's *Planet of the Apes* (1968) ended on the ruins of human civilization; its sequel, *Beneath the Planet of the Apes* (1970), discovered beneath New York a congregation of telepathic mutant humans worshipping a doomsday bomb in the ruins of a cathedral. *Fallout*'s Cathedral rises above a vault where the Master's psychic power assails intruders and where a nuclear device waits that the Vault Dweller may arm. No influence need be asserted for the resonance to matter: in both works, the cathedral is the place where the bomb becomes a god.

3.4 UNITY: THE MASTER'S POLITICAL PHILOSOPHY

The Master's doctrine of Unity holds that humanity's divisions—of race, creed, and nation—produced the war, and that the cure is a single species, stronger, more resilient, and undivided. The doctrine is sincere, intelligent, and catastrophic, and its power derives from the venerable philosophies it literalizes.

The first is Rousseau's. *The Social Contract* (1762) declares that whoever refuses to obey the general will shall be compelled to obey by the whole body, which means only that he will be forced to be free (I.7). Its account of the Legislator (II.7) is more uncanny still: whoever dares to institute a people must feel capable of changing human nature, of transforming each individual, complete and solitary in himself, into part of a greater whole from which he receives, in a sense, his life and being. The Master is Rousseau's Legislator with a laboratory. The vat is denaturation made literal, the change of human nature accomplished not by civic education but by virus; the greater whole is the mutant host; and "forced to be free" becomes "forced to evolve."

The second is Hegel's. The Master's very name invokes the *Herr* of the *Phenomenology of Spirit* (1807, §§178–196), the self-consciousness that wins the struggle for recognition only to find its victory hollow, since the recognition it receives comes from a bondsman it does not recognize, while history passes through the bondsman's fear and labor, which transform both world and self. The Master has no bondsman. His mutants are extensions of his will—his "Children"—who cannot recognize him because they are not other, and who labor without transforming the future because they cannot reproduce. He is a lord without a dialectic. Alexandre Kojève's lectures on Hegel (1947) described the end of history as a universal and homogeneous state in which post-historical humanity reverts to animal contentment. The Master's Unity is that state achieved

biologically, history abolished by abolishing the differences that drive it: Fukuyama's last man with green skin.

The third is Nietzsche's. In the prologue to *Thus Spoke Zarathustra* (§§3–5), humanity is a rope stretched over an abyss between beast and overman, and the overman is the meaning of the earth; against him stands the last man, who has invented happiness and blinks. Nietzsche's overman is an ethic of self-overcoming, not a breeding program. The Master commits the error of those readers, Elisabeth Förster-Nietzsche foremost, who turned Zarathustra into a eugenic prophet: he makes the overman into flesh. The super mutant is the *Übermensch* as kitsch. Yet the vat also manufactures the last man's condition—no striving, no succession, no future—so that overman and last man converge in a single sterile body.

The fourth is Schmitt's, by inversion. *The Concept of the Political* (1932) defines the political through the distinction between friend and enemy and warns that a world without that distinction would be a world without politics. The Master is the anti-Schmitt: he would abolish the political by abolishing the enemy, not through extermination but through assimilation. The Enclave of the sequel is the hyper-Schmitt, for whom everyone outside is the enemy. The diptych's two antagonists thus represent the two ways of ending the political: fusion and extermination.

The fifth is Camus's. *The Rebel* (1951) traces how metaphysical rebellion against the human condition becomes the justification of murder once it seeks totality, and insists that genuine revolt preserves a limit, its solidarity condensed in the formula "I rebel—therefore we exist." The Master rebels against division and, in the name of unity, abolishes the *we*.

The sixth is Haraway's, and it is decisive. "A Manifesto for Cyborgs" (1985) presents the cyborg as a creature of boundary confusion—between human and animal, organism and machine—without an origin story, refusing the dream of organic wholeness. The cyborg, Haraway writes, "would not recognize the Garden of Eden." The Master is a cyborg in body: the flesh of the man once called Richard Grey, fused with the computers of his vault, speaking in a chorus of human, inhuman, and mechanical voices. He is not a cyborg in desire. He dreams of organic Unity, of a return to wholeness, of a species without seams. He is the cyborg nostalgic for Eden, a being of pure hybridity who would abolish hybridity, and this contradiction is the key to his downfall and the thread that binds the Vat to the Garden.

3.5 A LITERARY GENEALOGY OF THE VAT

Mary Shelley's *Frankenstein* (1818) supplies the founding scene. The creature demands a mate; Victor begins her, then tears her apart, fearing that a race of devils would be propagated upon the earth. The creator prohibits his creation's natality. The Master internalizes Victor's prohibition into the creature's biology: his mutants are made already denied the female, born, as it were, after the destruction of their Eve.

H. G. Wells's *The Island of Doctor Moreau* (1896) gives the Vat its laboratory: vivisected Beast Folk, the chanted Law, the House of Pain, and the inevitable reversion of the creatures to animality. Avellone's *Fallout Bible* later supplied the Master's human name with the surname Moreau, a paratextual signature confirming the lineage. Moreau's creatures revert; the Master's do not revert—they end. The series' later lore also makes the Master an exile, recording Richard Moreau's expulsion from Vault City for murder in 2092. Exile is therefore necessary but not sufficient for natality: the Vault paradigm casts out both the Master and the Vault Dweller, and what divides them is what each builds outside—a fusion in one case, a plurality in the other. Olaf Stapledon's *Last and First Men* (1930) narrates successive human species, among them the Fourth Men who engineer the Fifth, making directed evolution the substance of cosmic history. Theodore Sturgeon's *More Than Human* (1953) imagines *homo gestalt*, a single being composed of several persons, a precedent for the Master's many voices. Arthur C. Clarke's *Childhood's End* (1953) dissolves the last generation of human children into the Overmind and presents the end of humanity as transcendence.

John Wyndham's *The Chrysalids* (1955) is the most illuminating comparandum, because it contains both of the diptych's antagonists in a single frame. Waknuk, a postnuclear theocracy, hunts genetic "Deviations" in the name of the true image of man; Sealand, a society of advanced telepaths, sends an envoy who declares the old species doomed and claims the evolutionary right of the new. Waknuk is the Enclave; Sealand speaks the Master's language. Wyndham, notoriously, sides with Sealand. *Fallout* refuses both.

Octavia E. Butler's *Dawn* (1987), first volume of the *Xenogenesis* trilogy, imagines the alien Oankali rescuing humanity's survivors after nuclear war and diagnosing a fatal "Contradiction"—intelligence placed in the service of hierarchical behavior—for which they offer genetic exchange as the price of survival. The Master's diagnosis is identical and his remedy coercive; Butler's ambivalence is more honest than Wyndham's triumphalism and closer to *Fallout*'s refusal. Katsuhiro Ōtomo's *Akira* (manga 1982–1990; film 1988) renders the Master's body before the fact, as Tetsuo's swelling flesh absorbs machines and persons. Margaret Atwood's *Oryx and Crake* (2003) unites the two antagonists in one figure: Crake engineers a gentle successor species and exterminates humanity with a virus, a synthesis of Unity and Purity that *Fallout* holds apart across two games.

3.6 EVOLUTION FORCED

"Forced evolution" is a contradiction in Darwinian terms. Natural selection, as *On the Origin of Species* (1859) describes it, acts without foresight on undirected variation; evolution has no goal. The virus embodies a Lamarckian and teleological fantasy, akin to Lamarck's inner drive toward complexity in the *Philosophie zoologique* (1809): evolution as program, as direction imposed. The Master's error is metaphysical before it is political. He mistakes evolution for a ladder with a top.

The historical correlate is eugenics, and its history has named perpetrators and victims. Francis Galton coined the term in *Inquiries into Human Faculty* (1883), building on *Hereditary Genius* (1869), and Herbert Spencer's "survival of the fittest" (1864) lent the movement its slogan. In *Buck v. Bell* (1927) the United States Supreme Court, by eight votes to one, upheld the Commonwealth of Virginia's sterilization of Carrie Buck, whom her foster family had committed to the State Colony for Epileptics and Feeble-Minded after she was raped by one of their relatives and became pregnant; the diagnosis of "feeble-mindedness" has since been shown to be false, and her own lawyer colluded with the Colony's to secure the ruling. Justice Holmes declared that three generations of imbeciles were enough, and under such laws American states sterilized more than 60,000 people. Nazi Germany's Law for the Prevention of Hereditarily Diseased Offspring (1933), closely modeled on the American eugenicist Harry Laughlin's Model Eugenical Sterilization Law, led to the forced sterilization of between 350,000 and 400,000 people. Under the regime's "euthanasia" program, later called Aktion T4 and organized and carried out largely by physicians, 70,273 adult patients were murdered in the gas chambers of six killing centers between January 1940 and August 1941; counting the killings that continued until 1945, the victims probably numbered a quarter of a million. Most of the German staff of the Operation Reinhard extermination camps—Bełżec, Sobibór, and Treblinka—came from T4, and Operation Reinhard's personnel murdered approximately 1.7 million Jews in those camps and in related mass shootings. At the Nuremberg Doctors' Trial the defense cited *Buck v. Bell*. The eugenicists sterilized and then killed those they classed as unfit in order to perfect the race. The Master perfects the race and finds it sterile. Followed to its end, the eugenic dream does not purify generation; it abolishes it.

The Vat and the Vault converge once more. The Master needs Vault dwellers because irradiated bodies make poor mutants; the sequel's Enclave will need them because they are genetically pure controls. Both nightmares feed on the Vault's immunized bodies, and the Vault stands revealed as the common source of the series' two great anti-natal projects.

3.7 THE DEFEAT BY LOGOS

The Vault Dweller can defeat the Master by argument. Presented with evidence that his mutants are sterile, the Master recognizes that Unity is a dead end—a race that cannot continue itself—and destroys himself and his lair. Few works of the period permit their final antagonist to be refuted, and the possibility constitutes a philosophical claim in its own right.

Aristotle's *Poetics* (11, 1452a) holds that the finest plots unite *peripeteia*, reversal, with *anagnōrisis*, recognition, as when the messenger's news in *Oedipus Tyrannus* reverses fortune by revealing identity. The Master's end is tragic in this strict sense. His *hamartia* is a misrecognition of life itself, a failure to see that a species is not a state but a succession; recognition produces reversal, and like Oedipus he turns his power upon himself. The dialogue is also a Socratic *elenchus*, refuting the interlocutor from his own premises: the Master values Unity as the future of life; the evidence shows that Unity forecloses the future; the contradiction compels assent.

The scene admits an epistemological reading. Hilary Putnam's brain in a vat (*Reason, Truth and History*, 1981) modernized the Cartesian skeptic; the Master is a collective *cogito* sealed in machines, whose world is a projection of his will through psychic force and obedient servants. The evidence of sterility is testimony from outside the vat. The skeptic's enclosure collapses into recognition, and the suicide reverses the Cartesian scenario: the brain in the vat learns that the world exists and that it has no place in it.

Hannah Arendt's *The Human Condition* (1958, §31) diagnoses the tradition, inaugurated by Plato, that substitutes making for acting, replacing the unpredictable, plural, and natal character of action with the model of a craftsman realizing a design. The Master is *homo faber* who mistakes politics for fabrication and makes a people that cannot be born. Arendt names natality, the birth of new beings capable of new beginnings, as the miracle that saves the world from ruin (§34). The Master's defeat is natality's revenge on fabrication.

The Speech skill thereby inverts Clausewitz: dialogue becomes the continuation of war by other means, and in this case its conclusion. The Vat stands revealed as anti-natal sovereignty in its most seductive form—not enclosure but fusion, not purity but unity—and its truth is sterility. That the logos route is itself gated by intellect and training, so that peace becomes an aristocratic privilege, is a residue the thesis confronts in Chapter 8.



CHAPTER 4

STEEL AND SCRIPTURE

The Brotherhood, the Archive, and the Re-enchantment of Technology

IF THE VAT SACRALIZES biology, the Brotherhood of Steel sacralizes technology: it is a monastery of machines, a hierocracy whose sacred goods are power armor and holodisks, and whose vow is not poverty but retention. This chapter reads the Brotherhood, its initiation, and the wider re-enchantment of technology in the wasteland as the immunitary paradigm applied to knowledge, and it closes by following the games' most playful inquiry, into minds that migrate between bodies, toward the question of who counts as a person.

4.1 A MONASTERY OF MACHINES

Born of Roger Maxson's secession at Mariposa, the Brotherhood is by 2161 a hereditary and hierarchical order, governed by a Maxson as High Elder and ranked through elders, paladins, knights, scribes, and initiates. It hoards pre-war technology, keeps the wasteland at arm's length, and admits outsiders only through an ordeal. Its scribes study what the war left behind, the mutants included. Its paladins in power armor are the most formidable soldiers of the first game, and their formidability is the measure of what they withhold.

Walter M. Miller Jr.'s *A Canticle for Leibowitz* (1959) is the order's clearest literary antecedent. After the Flame Deluge and the Simplification, the anti-intellectual purge in which the learned were hunted and books burned, the Albertian Order of Leibowitz preserves the Memorabilia, copying and illuminating blueprints it cannot understand; over centuries a new Renaissance arises from its labors and culminates in a second nuclear war. The Brotherhood is the Albertian Order with its polarity reversed. Miller's monks preserve what they do not understand and eventually give it away; the Brotherhood understands what it preserves and keeps it. It is Prometheus who keeps the fire.

Leigh Brackett's *The Long Tomorrow* (1955) supplies a second antecedent: a post-nuclear United States whose constitution forbids cities, governed by an agrarian piety, beneath which the rumored Bartorstown secretly preserves nuclear knowledge in an underground installation. Technological custodianship becomes a secret society, the bunker a sanctuary of forbidden science. H. G. Wells's *The Shape of Things to Come* (1933), filmed by William Cameron Menzies as *Things to Come* (1936), furnishes a third: after a generational war, the airmen's technocracy of Wings Over the World subdues the warlords and imposes a rational order from the sky. The Brotherhood's paladins are Wells's airmen grounded, and the Enclave's vertibirds will be Wells's airmen restored to the air.

The order's ranks—knights, paladins, elders—recall the military-monastic orders of the Crusades, the Templars, Hospitallers, and Teutonic Knights, in which priestly and martial functions were fused. In Weber's sociology of domination, the Brotherhood is a hierocracy, a rule exercised by those who administer sacred goods. Its sacred goods are machines, and its theology is the conviction that the wasteland is not worthy of them.

4.2 ARCHIVE FEVER

Derrida's *Archive Fever* (1995) derives the archive from the Greek *arkheion*, the house of the archons, the magistrates who held and interpreted official documents. The archive is the place where commencement and commandment coincide, where origins are kept by those who command, and its fever binds the drive to conserve to the death drive Freud described in *Beyond the Pleasure Principle* (1920), an archiviolithic force that destroys even as it preserves. The Brotherhood's elders are archons in the strict sense. They hold the documents and the technologies of origin, interpret them, and command by virtue of holding them, and their conservation becomes isolation. An archive kept from use is an archive in decay; the order that will not share its knowledge cannot renew its membership, and the closed bunker repeats the Overseer's Paradox in the register of knowledge. Knowledge, too, can be immunized.

The first game supplies a counter-archive. In the library of the Boneyard, the Followers of the Apocalypse, led by Nicole, devote themselves to preserving and disseminating knowledge and to opposing the Master's cult. Bunker and library are the two possible archives of the wasteland: the archive as immunity, exempting its holders from the debt of knowledge, and the archive as *munus*, a gift owed to others. The opposition reproduces, at the level of learning, the antithesis between the Vault and the open door.

The games themselves are archives. Their worlds are documented in holodisks and terminal records; the Pip-Boy accumulates quest entries, notes, and maps; and the player, moving through ruins, becomes an archivist of the dead civilization, assembling its history from fragments. The epilogue is the archive's final catalogue. In this sense *Fallout* stages its own archive fever and resolves it on the side of the library: everything the player learns is learned in order to be used.

4.3 KATABASIS IN THE GLOW

The Brotherhood's initiation requires the candidate to descend into the Glow—the ruined West Tek research facility, struck in the war and saturated with radiation—and return with a holodisk. The ordeal is a *katabasis*, the descent to the dead in search of knowledge that structures Odysseus's *nekyia* (*Odyssey* XI), Aeneas's journey with the Sibyl (*Aeneid* VI), and Dante's *Inferno*. In the Glow, the knowledge sought lies among skeletons in the most contaminated place in the wasteland, and what the holodisk records is the genealogy of the virus: the origin of the enemy is found in the radioactive heart of the pre-war state.

The initiation reverses the logic of the sanctuary. In the Jerusalem Temple the Holy of Holies was the purest place, entered once a year by a purified priest; the Brotherhood's sacred center is the most polluted place, entered by an outsider fortified with anti-radiation drugs. The order of steel and retention is founded on exposure.

Here, at the threshold of the most immunitary institution in the first game, *felix contaminatio* appears as rite: to join the pure, one must first be contaminated.

Heidegger's "The Question Concerning Technology" (1954) names the essence of modern technology *Gestell*, enframing, a mode of revealing that challenges forth nature and humanity alike as *Bestand*, standing-reserve. The supreme danger is that human beings themselves come to be revealed as standing-reserve. West Tek and Mariposa enframe humanity in exactly this sense: prisoners as experimental reserve, populations as subjects, species as raw material for an evolution on demand. Heidegger closes by citing Hölderlin's "Patmos": *Wo aber Gefahr ist, wächst / Das Rettende auch*—where danger is, the saving power also grows. The Glow is the topography of that couplet, the place of greatest danger in which the saving knowledge grows.

The Glow is also where the sublime collapses. Burke's *Philosophical Enquiry* (1757) located the delight of terror in its distance, and Kant's *Critique of Judgment* (§28) held that nature's might is sublime only when we behold it from safety, so that it awakens our consciousness of a rational vocation superior to nature. Frances Ferguson's "The Nuclear Sublime" (1984) argued that the nuclear threat abolishes the safe distance on which the sublime depends, while Peter B. Hales traced the postwar construction of an "atomic sublime" in images of the bomb. The Glow is a sublime without distance and without spectacle: its danger is invisible, measured by a Geiger counter and counteracted by dosage. In the irradiated ruin the sublime becomes pharmacology.

4.4 THE CHARISMA OF THINGS

Weber's "Science as a Vocation" (1917/1919) defined the disenchantment of the world as the knowledge that no mysterious, incalculable forces intervene, that all things can in principle be mastered by calculation. *Fallout* re-enchants the world through the very technology that disenchanted it. The Brotherhood treats machines as sacred goods; the tribe of Arroyo venerates a Vault jumpsuit as a relic and the G.E.C.K. as a grail; the Children of the Cathedral preach unity over a nuclear device; and in the sequel's San Francisco, the Hubologists, a transparent parody of the Scientology founded on L. Ron Hubbard's *Dianetics* (1950), sell graded spiritual advancement and an escape to the stars, while the Shi consult an oracular computer they call the Emperor.

Arthur C. Clarke's third law holds that any sufficiently advanced technology is indistinguishable from magic. *Fallout* proposes a converse: sufficiently degraded technology becomes indistinguishable from relic. Peter Worsley's *The Trumpet Shall Sound* (1957) studied Melanesian cargo cults, in which ritual imitation of colonial technology was meant to summon its goods, and the games' tribal reverence for Vault-Tec objects invites the comparison. Yet the comparison cuts both ways. The Brotherhood's veneration of its machines is no less a cargo cult than Arroyo's veneration of its jumpsuit; the difference lies only in which cult can read the manual.

Mircea Eliade's *The Sacred and the Profane* (1957) describes hierophany, the manifestation of the sacred in a profane object. Pre-war technology is the wasteland's hierophany. In medieval Christianity relics were the remains of the holy dead; in *Fallout* they are the remains of a dead civilization whose saints were engineers. What Weber called charisma, the extraordinary quality of a person, migrates to objects. The result is a charisma of things that binds the wasteland's new sovereignties to the old one: to possess the relics of the pre-war state is to claim its authority.

4.5 MINDS IN MACHINES, PERSONS BEYOND SPECIES

At the Sierra Army Depot in *Fallout 2*, an artificial intelligence named Skynet, after the machine of *The Terminator* (1984), asks the Chosen One for a brain to install in a robotic body. The player may supply a human brain, a chimpanzee brain, an "abnormal" brain, or a cybernetic one, and the choice alters the resulting companion's capacities. The episode is a vernacular seminar in the philosophy of mind. It stages Hilary Putnam's functionalist thesis of multiple realizability (1967), according to which mental states are defined by their functional roles rather than their substrate, and it invites the objections of John Searle's Chinese Room (1980) and Thomas Nagel's question of what it is like to be a bat (1974). The game answers with comic functionalism: the brain is a component, and its provenance changes the statistics, not the being.

The joke has a serious corollary. If mind is indifferent to substrate, the boundaries of personhood are not the boundaries of species. John Locke defined a person as a thinking, intelligent being that has reason and reflection and can consider itself as itself in different times and places (*Essay* II.27 §9), and his anecdote of Prince Maurice's rational parrot (II.27 §8) had already pried "person" away from "man." *Fallout 2* assembles its companions as a gallery of Lockean persons beyond the human: Marcus, a super mutant and veteran of the Master's army; Lenny, a ghoul physician; Goris, a Deathclaw of Vault 13 who conceals a scholar's intelligence; Skynet; a cybernetic dog. The Deathclaws of Vault 13, products of an Enclave program, have developed speech and a social order; instruments made for war have become a people. Peter Singer's *Animal Liberation* (1975) named the prejudice that privileges membership in a species over the capacities that ground moral consideration, and the sequel's companions are a sustained argument against it.

The question of who counts as a person becomes, in the wasteland's polities, the question of who counts as a citizen. The next chapter turns from the sacred to the political, and from the machine to the state.



CHAPTER 5

LEVIATHAN IN THE RUINS

Exchange, Violence, and the Genealogy of the Wasteland State

THE WASTELAND IS NOT a state of nature but a laboratory of state formation. In its settlements the games stage, one after another, the rival genealogies of political order that modern philosophy has proposed—Hobbes's covenant, Locke's property, Rousseau's enclosure, Nozick's protective agencies, Weber's monopoly of violence—and they render the emergence of the state not as an escape from war but as war's reorganization. This chapter follows that genealogy from Junktown to the New California Republic, attending to the two economies, of water and of vice, on which the wasteland's sovereignties are founded, and to the two exclusions, servitude and slavery, by which they are policed.

5.1 NOT A STATE OF NATURE

Hobbes's *Leviathan* (1651, ch. XIII) imagines humanity without a common power as a war of every man against every man, in which there is no industry, no agriculture, no arts, no letters, no society, and the life of man is solitary, poor, nasty, brutish, and short; *De Cive* (1642) had named it the war of all against all. The wasteland invites the Hobbesian reading—raiders such as the Khans, the Vipers, and the Jackals prey on caravans, and radscorpions and mutants stalk the roads—and then refuses it. The world the Vault Dweller enters is thickly social: farming villages, trading towns, merchant houses, churches, a library, a monastic order of technologists. The wasteland refutes Hobbes as an anthropologist even as it confirms him as a theorist of sovereignty. Society survives the collapse of the state; the state returns, and it returns as the answer to the question of who may use force.

Locke's *Second Treatise* (1689) grants the state of nature a law of reason and derives property from the mixing of labor with what nature provides (ch. V), a right limited at first by spoilage and liberated from that limit by money. Rousseau's *Discourse on Inequality* (1755) finds the true founder of civil society in the first person who enclosed a plot of ground, declared it his own, and found others simple enough to believe him. In *Fallout* the enclosure precedes the catastrophe. The Vault is the founding "this is mine" of the post-war order, its first fence, and Rousseau's genealogy of inequality is the series' literal prehistory: the war began with a door.

Robert Nozick's *Anarchy, State, and Utopia* (1974) proposed that a minimal state could arise without injustice from competing protective associations, one of which becomes dominant through an invisible-hand process. *Fallout* stages this genealogy and refutes its innocence. Its towns are guarded by Junktown's watch, by the Hub's police and the merchant houses' caravan guards, and by the Regulators of the Boneyard, a protection force whose guardianship curdles into predation; its roads are patrolled by the Desert Rangers, whose veteran Tycho is a homage to Interplay's *Wasteland* (1988), and in the sequel by the Rangers of the New California Republic. Protective agencies become predators or empires. The invisible hand holds a gun.

Max Weber's "Politics as a Vocation" (1919) defined the state as the human community that successfully claims the monopoly of the legitimate use of physical force within a territory, and distinguished three grounds of legitimacy: tradition, charisma, and legal-rational rule. The diptych reads as a Weberian typology rendered in settlements. Arroyo's Elder and the Brotherhood's hereditary Maxsons rule by tradition; the Master and his Cathedral by charisma and its routinization; Vault City's council and the New California Republic by statute and office. Every town poses Weber's question—who here may kill, and why do the others accept it?—and every town answers it differently.

5.2 JUNKTOWN AND THE STRANGER-SOVEREIGN

Junktown, the first town many players reach, is divided between two sovereignties. Killian Darkwater, shopkeeper and mayor, embodies a nascent rule of law: order, property, and a jail. Gizmo, the corpulent proprietor of the casino, embodies the patrimonial sovereignty of crime: protection sold, loyalty bought, rivals removed. Gizmo plots Killian's assassination; the Vault Dweller may expose the plot or carry it out, and the epilogue weighs the costs of either settlement. The choice is not between order and chaos but between two orders, each with its price.

The structure has a lineage. Dashiell Hammett's *Red Harvest* (1929) sends the Continental Op into Personville, a mining town its inhabitants call Poisonville, owned by rival gangs whom the Op sets against one another until the town drowns in blood. Akira Kurosawa's *Yojimbo* (1961) and Sergio Leone's *A Fistful of Dollars* (1964) restage the plot with a masterless samurai and a nameless gunslinger. The Vault Dweller is the Op, the ronin, the Man with No Name: an outsider who decides which sovereignty survives. Georg Simmel's "The Stranger" (1908) describes the figure who comes today and stays tomorrow, near and remote at once, whose freedom from local bonds makes him the natural arbiter. The role-playing game makes its protagonist a stranger in every town and therefore a sovereign in Schmitt's sense in each: the one who decides the exception. Machiavelli held that a founder must be alone (*Discourses* I.9), excusing Romulus's fratricide by the foundation it secured. The wasteland's founders are alone because they are passing through.

5.3 THE WATER STANDARD

The Hub, the commercial capital of the first game, is organized by merchant houses—the Water Merchants, the Crimson Caravan, the Far Go Traders—beneath which a criminal underground flourishes. Its currency is the bottle cap, and the cap's value is secured by the Water Merchants' willingness to exchange caps for water. The first game's economy runs on a water standard.

Beneath the currency lies the barter screen, on which the player exchanges goods directly, every object implicitly commensurated with every other. The interface restages

the economists' origin myth. Adam Smith's *Wealth of Nations* (1776, I.4) derived money from the inconvenience of barter, a story William Stanley Jevons crystallized as the problem of the double coincidence of wants (1875). Anthropology has dismantled the myth. Caroline Humphrey observed in 1985 that no example of a barter economy from which money emerged had ever been described, and David Graeber's *Debt: The First 5,000 Years* (2011) argued that credit and debt precede coinage. Humphrey's own title supplies the key to *Fallout*'s economy: "Barter and Economic Disintegration." Barter appears not at the origin of monetary economies but in their ruins. The barter screen is not primitive; it is post-monetary, the economic form of collapse.

The cap is the purest Lockean money imaginable. Locke described money as a durable thing that people, by mutual consent, accept in exchange for perishable necessities, permitting accumulation beyond use and thereby legitimizing unequal possession (*Second Treatise* §§46–50). The cap is useless, durable, and conventional, a residue of pre-war consumption—the crimped lid of a soft drink—whose value is underwritten by the one thing no one can do without. Marx's analysis of the money commodity and its fetish character (*Capital* I, ch. 1 §4 and ch. 3) finds an exemplary object here: a social relation among survivors appears as a relation among bottle caps. Simmel's *Philosophy of Money* (1900) treated money as the objectification of exchange itself, the purest of means; the cap is pure means underwritten by the purest of ends, thirst.

Karl Wittfogel's *Oriental Despotism* (1957), a contested thesis, argued that control of large-scale irrigation underwrote despotic bureaucracies. Whatever its historical merits, the hydraulic thesis illuminates *Fallout*. The Water Merchants are a central bank of thirst; the Vault's survival hangs on a water chip; the first game's political economy is hydraulic from its premise to its currency. By the sequel the cap standard has given way to the money of an emergent state, a passage from merchant hydraulics to state seigniorage that Karl Polanyi's *The Great Transformation* (1944) would have recognized: markets are instituted, and states make money. Fredric Jameson observed that it has become easier to imagine the end of the world than the end of capitalism. *Fallout* imagines the end of the world and finds capitalism among the survivors, not as a mode of production but as the monetization of survival.

5.4 NEW RENO: THE MARKET OF VICE

If the Hub is the economy of necessity, New Reno is the economy of desire. Four crime families—the Mordinos, the Wrights, the Bishops, and the Salvatores—divide a city of casinos, boxing rings, brothels, a pornographic film studio, and Jet, an addictive stimulant that the adolescent chemist Myron synthesizes, the game informs us, from the fumes of brahmin dung. Jet is the ideal commodity of consumer capitalism: produced from waste, it produces its own demand. Marx's fetish here acquires a pharmacology. The commodity no longer merely conceals the social relation that produced it; it manufactures the dependence that consumes it.

The city has a cinematic ancestor in the Bartertown of *Mad Max Beyond Thunderdome* (1985), powered by methane from pig dung processed in its underworld, governed by Aunty Entity's market, and adjudicated in the Thunderdome, where combat is at once law and spectacle. New Reno draws its narcotic from excrement, stages its justice in a boxing ring, and recognizes no law but the market. Mikhail Bakhtin's *Rabelais and His World* (1965) celebrated carnival as a regenerative inversion in which the grotesque body and ambivalent laughter renew the world. New Reno is carnival commodified: transgression sold by the hour, inversion without renewal. The Chosen One may play the families against one another as the Op played Personville's gangs, may become a "Made Man," and may notice that the Salvatores' energy weapons betray a commerce with the Enclave. The market is the conduit through which the last sovereign arms the wasteland's gangsters.

5.5 VAULT CITY: CITIZENSHIP AS IMMUNITY

Vault City is the sequel's most civilized place and its clearest document of barbarism. Founded by the residents of Vault 8, the control vault that opened as designed, it maintains a walled inner city of citizens, an outer Courtyard for the unenfranchised, and a class of "servants" whose indentured servitude is slavery by another name, justified as a civilizing tutelage. Its citizenship is jealously guarded; its leaders despise the ghouls of neighboring Gecko and fear the radiation leaking from their reactor; its First Citizen, Lynette, embodies a technocratic xenophobia. Its streets are clean and its medicine excellent.

The model is Athenian. Pericles' citizenship law of 451/450 BCE restricted citizenship to the children of two Athenian parents, and the freedom of the democratic polis rested on the labor of the enslaved. Aristotle's *Politics* (I.4–7) defined the slave as a living tool and defended slavery by nature for those who, in his view, could apprehend reason without possessing it. Vault City's servants are Aristotle's natural slaves restored under the euphemism of contract, and Benjamin's seventh thesis—no document of civilization that is not also a document of barbarism—could serve as the city's motto.

Arendt's analysis of the stateless in *The Origins of Totalitarianism* (1951, ch. 9), as those who have lost the "right to have rights," names the condition of the Courtyard's inhabitants: present in the polis, absent from its law. In Esposito's terms citizenship is the immunitary membrane of the polis, and Vault City is the Vault paradigm reconstituted after the door has opened: the wall rebuilt as law. That this city was founded with a Garden of Eden Creation Kit, the very object the Chosen One seeks, is the sequel's most pointed irony, to which Chapter 7 returns.

5.6 GECKO AND BROKEN HILLS: THE COSMOPOLITAN WAGER

Gecko, a ghoul settlement clustered around a nuclear power plant and home to Harold, the ghoul who links the two games, is Vault City's abjected neighbor. The Chosen One may repair the plant and broker cooperation between the towns, exchanging power for recognition, or abandon Gecko to Vault City's hostility. Kant's *Toward Perpetual Peace* (1795) placed its hope in two mechanisms that this episode stages. Its first supplement trusts the spirit of commerce, which cannot coexist with war and sooner or later takes hold of every people; its third definitive article limits cosmopolitan right to the conditions of universal hospitality, the right of a stranger not to be treated with hostility on arrival in another's land. The Gecko settlement is a Kantian peace in miniature—commerce first, hospitality after—extended across the boundary between the pure and the contaminated.

Broken Hills goes further. A uranium-mining town in which humans, ghouls, and super mutants live and work together, it is protected by Marcus, a super mutant and veteran of the Master's army who has inverted the doctrine he once served. A conspiracy of human purists threatens the town from within, and the threat is the point: the series' most explicit image of a mutant cosmopolis is besieged not by monsters but by purity. Arendt grounded political action in plurality, the fact that men, not Man, live on the earth and inhabit the world (*The Human Condition* §1). The Master sought Man; his former soldier keeps a town of men, ghouls, and mutants. Broken Hills is Arendt's correction of the Master, enacted by the Master's own creature.

5.7 THE DEN: NATAL ALIENATION AND THE INVERTED STIGMA

In the Den, slavers under Metzger's guild trade in human beings, and a player who joins them receives a slaver's tattoo on the forehead and a reputation that the Rangers of the New California Republic, sworn against slavery, will remember. Orlando Patterson's *Slavery and Social Death* (1982) defined slavery as the permanent, violent domination of natally alienated and generally dishonored persons. Natal alienation—the severance of the enslaved from claims of ancestry and descent—is the polis's internal anti-natality. What the vat is to the species and the Vault is to time, slavery is to the political community: the abolition of birth's claims within the body politic itself.

Erving Goffman's *Stigma* (1963) begins with the Greek *stigma*, a sign cut or burned into the body to advertise the bearer's moral status—slave, criminal, traitor. The Den's tattoo inverts historical stigma. It marks not the enslaved but the enslaver, relocating dishonor from the slave to the slaver and inscribing the series' moral topology on the face. Between the Den and Vault City the sequel draws a lesson about euphemism: the honest slaver brands himself, while the polite one calls his slaves servants and teaches them gratitude.

5.8 THE RETURN OF THE REPUBLIC

The first game's Shady Sands, a farming village that the later lore says Vault 15's survivors founded in 2142 with their vault's G.E.C.K., is led by Aradesh, whose daughter Tandi the Vault Dweller may rescue from the Khans. By the sequel the village has become the core of the New California Republic, and Tandi, now very old, is its President. The republic has acquired the apparatus of a state—a bureaucracy, ranching interests, rangers, and a territorial appetite that presses on Vault City and on the mining town of Redding—and its flag bears the bear of the old California Republic with two heads. The republic's heraldry is a mutant.

Arendt's *On Revolution* (1963) treats foundation as the constitution of freedom and dwells on the fragility of foundations once their founders die. Machiavelli counseled republics to endure by returning to their first principles (*Discourses* III.1); Polybius described *anacyclosis*, the cycle by which kingship decays into tyranny, aristocracy into oligarchy, democracy into mob rule, and mob rule into monarchy once more (*Histories* VI.4–9). The republic's trajectory from village to state to expanding power intimates the cycle, and "war never changes" can be heard as *anacyclosis*. Yet the republic began with an act of exilic natality: the rescue of Tandi, performed by someone the Vault would soon expel, seeded the state. The diptych's political philosophy is tragic without being fatalist. Every foundation carries its recurrence, but the two-headed bear hints at another heraldic principle: a polity that bears its contamination as its emblem.



CHAPTER 6

THE LAST AMERICANS

The Enclave, Purity, and the Autoimmune Sovereign

THE ENCLAVE IS THE series' answer to the question of what became of the pre-war state: not a ruin but a remainder, a sovereignty that survived its people and now proposes to replace them. This chapter reads the Enclave's purity plan as the terminus of the immunological plot, as an autoimmune crisis of sovereignty, and as the secession of the state from the earth, and it reads the Chosen One's victory as the defeat of purity by the impure.

6.1 CONTINUITY OF GOVERNMENT

The Enclave is the remnant of the pre-war government of the United States and of the military and corporate elite that sheltered with it. It governs from a Poseidon Energy oil platform off the California coast, projects force from a mainland base at Navarro, flies vertibirds, clothes its soldiers in advanced power armor, and is led by President Dick Richardson. It is the posthumous child of the continuity-of-government architecture described in Chapter 1, Strangelove's mineshaft become a polity, and it reverses the structure of Dick's *The Penultimate Truth*: the elite now occupy the sealed place, while the people live, mutate, and die on the surface.

Ernst Kantorowicz's *The King's Two Bodies* (1957) reconstructed the medieval doctrine by which the king possessed a mortal body natural and an immortal body politic, so that the dignity of the crown never died. The Enclave is a body politic that has outlived its body natural—not the king's but the nation's. The office persists after the people it represented have been reclassified as something else. In Derrida's vocabulary it is a specter, neither living nor dead, and its claim to legitimacy is pure continuity: it is the government of the United States because it never stopped saying so. It is also the Vault paradigm at sovereign scale. The oil platform is the Vault of the state.

6.2 THE PURITY PLAN

The Enclave's scientists have refined the Forced Evolutionary Virus into Curling-13, a pathogen designed to kill every organism whose genes radiation has altered—in effect, nearly every living person in the wasteland—while sparing the Enclave's own population, which has lived apart from the fallout. To test it, the Enclave has abducted the residents of Vault 13, genetically pure controls, and the villagers of Arroyo. Its taxonomy has already declared the wasteland's inhabitants mutants. From its standpoint the human race has ended and survives only on the platform; the plan merely brings biology into line with classification.

Foucault's lecture of 17 March 1976 in *"Society Must Be Defended"* describes the biopolitical state's power to make live and let die, and identifies racism as the caesura it introduces into the biological continuum of the population—the break between what must live and what must die that alone permits a power devoted to life to kill. The case from which Foucault, Agamben, and Esposito reason should be named: Nazi Germany,

whose state murdered some six million European Jews, together with Roma and Sinti, disabled people, and others it classed as biologically dangerous or unworthy of life. The Enclave's plan is racism without race only in the sense that its caesura is drawn by mutation rather than descent, and its biological purity is the biopolitical cut in its purest form. Its closest historical precedent is the Nazi murder of disabled people traced in Chapter 3, a killing program defined by imputed biological defect rather than ethnicity, whose methods and staff passed into the death camps. Agamben's sovereign, who decides on bare life, and Schmitt's, who decides on the exception (*Political Theology*, 1922), converge here: the Enclave decides that the whole wasteland is the exception.

Schmitt's warning about humanity completes the diagnosis. *The Concept of the Political* (§6) argues that humanity as such cannot wage war, for it has no enemy on this planet, and that a war waged in humanity's name denies the enemy's humanity and so becomes especially inhuman; Schmitt adapts Proudhon's dictum that whoever invokes humanity wants to cheat. The Enclave wages war in the name of pure humanity against the human majority. It is the logical terminus of "humanity" as an exclusionary concept, staged with a literalism Schmitt never imagined. The warning comes from a compromised witness: Schmitt joined the National Socialist party on 1 May 1933; in the summer of 1934 he published "Der Führer schützt das Recht," justifying the political murders of the Night of the Long Knives, and in 1936 he called for German law to be cleansed of what he termed the Jewish spirit. That the diagnosis holds despite its author is part of its force here.

Arendt's *The Origins of Totalitarianism* traced the conviction that whole categories of people are superfluous; *Eichmann in Jerusalem* (1963) located the banality of evil in functionaries who execute what they do not think. The Enclave's soldiers and scientists are functionaries of this kind, and the final confrontation allows for their defection: the Chosen One can persuade a squad of Enclave soldiers under Sergeant Granite to fight Frank Horrigan, the platform's last guardian, in exchange for passage off the platform, and can use the access key taken from the President's body to switch the platform's turrets into a counter-insurgency mode that turns them on him. The soldiers' defection is bought with a promise of escape rather than an appeal to conscience, yet it still recalls Maxson's secession at Mariposa. Even the most perfectly sealed machine of extermination depends on persons who might refuse.

6.3 AUTOIMMUNITY

Esposito's *Bios* (2004) reads Nazism as an autoimmune disease of the body politic, in which the immunitary drive to protect the life of the people, absolutized, culminated in Hitler's Nero Decree of 19 March 1945, which ordered the destruction of Germany's own infrastructure and, by Albert Speer's contemporaneous account, refused any consideration for what the defeated population would need to survive. Derrida's late writings ("Faith and Knowledge," 1996; *Rogues*, 2003) generalized autoimmunity as the process by which a living being destroys its own protections. The Enclave's virus is immunity's final form. It would achieve the pan-immunity the Forced Evolutionary Virus was first designed to deliver—by killing everyone who is not immune. The immunological plot closes its circle: from the Pan-Immunity Virion Project, through forced evolution and the super mutant, to Curling-13. The game even lets the autoimmune event be staged literally: the Chosen One can have the virus released into the platform's own air system, where it kills the Enclave's civilians and scientists—the purity weapon turned on its makers, and the player made, for that moment, the Enclave's double.

The purity is parasitic. The Enclave trades with New Reno's Salvatores, harvests its test subjects from Vault 13 and Arroyo, and depends on the wasteland it would annihilate. Its supreme guardian makes the autoimmune structure visible. Frank Horrigan, a Secret Service agent and the game's final adversary, is himself a monstrous product of the virus: the regime of purity is guarded by the most mutated body in the game. Esposito's central insight, that immunity incorporates the negative it opposes, could have no more literal emblem.

Power armor completes the anatomy. The sealed suit is the Vault become garment, an immunitary prosthesis that shields the body from the world; the Enclave's purity is the Vault become genome. The immunitary series thus runs from architecture (the Vault) through prosthesis (the armor) to biology (the virus). Bakhtin's opposition between the classical body—closed, finished, smooth—and the grotesque body—open, protruding, in becoming—maps exactly onto the series' figures: the Enclave's armored soldiers on one side, and on the other the ghouls, mutants, and tribals whose bodies are open to the world.

6.4 PETRO-SOVEREIGNTY AND THE NOMOS OF THE SEA

The first game's opening named petroleum and uranium as the prizes of the last war; the sequel ends on an oil platform and leaves it aboard a tanker named the *Valdez*, recalling the Exxon *Valdez* spill of 1989. Timothy Mitchell's *Carbon Democracy* (2011) argues that the political forms of the twentieth century were shaped by the material properties of oil, and Amitav Ghosh's "Petrofiction" (1992) observed how rarely the novel has managed to represent oil at all. *Fallout 2* is a petrofiction in Ghosh's sense. The last American sovereignty is a petro-sovereignty seated on a drilling platform, and its destruction, when the Chosen One sends the platform's reactor critical, is the exhaustion of a carbon state.

Schmitt's *Land and Sea* (1942) and *The Nomos of the Earth* (1950) ground every legal order in an original appropriation of land and contrast the terrestrial order of fixed boundaries with the sea, an element on which no lines can be drawn. The Enclave has withdrawn from the earth's *nomos* to the sea, and from there it decides on the land's annihilation. It is a sovereignty that has seceded from the earth—from the soil, the water, and the bodies that fallout has touched—and that judges the earth from a platform anchored nowhere. The Chosen One returns judgment to the land.

6.5 NECROPOLIS AND THE REMNANT

Achille Mbembe's "Necropolitics" (2003) defines sovereignty as the capacity to dictate who may live and who must die, and describes the creation of death-worlds in which populations are subjected to conditions that confer on them the status of the living dead. *Fallout* named one of its first cities Necropolis. Its ghouls descend from Vault 12, whose door Vault-Tec engineered never to close; they are the living dead of a death-world designed by the pre-war state, subjects of necropolitics in the most literal sense.

Yet the ghoul outlives the regime that made it. Harold, who appears in the Hub in the first game and in Gecko in the second, witnesses the arc of the series in a single decaying body. Agamben's *The Time That Remains* (2000) reads Paul's remnant (Romans 11:5) not as a numerical portion of Israel but as the people's non-coincidence with itself, the remainder that prevents any people from being whole. The ghoul is the remnant of the American people in this sense, the living refutation of the Enclave's claim to be the nation's pure continuity. The people survive not as a sealed elite but as an exposed remainder, and their witness is Benjamin's angel given flesh. Judith Butler's *Precarious Life* (2004) and *Frames of War* (2009) ask which lives are grievable. The Enclave's frame renders the whole wasteland ungrievable; the sequel's companions, ghouls and mutants among them, restore the grief the frame forbids.

6.6 THE IMPURE AGENT

The Chosen One is tribal, descended from an exile, and by the Enclave's taxonomy a mutant. The contaminated destroys the pure, and in doing so rescues the pure Vault 13 dwellers from the purer Enclave. Aldous Huxley imagined both halves of this confrontation and resolved neither in hope. In *Brave New World* (1932), John the Savage leaves the Reservation, confronts the World State, and is destroyed by it. In *Ape and Essence* (1948), Los Angeles in the twenty-second century, after a nuclear war, has become a theocracy that worships Belial and kills deformed infants in rites of purification—a contaminated society practicing purity as liturgy, an uncanny anticipation of both the Boneyard's cathedral and the Enclave's plan. *Fallout 2* reverses Huxley's tragedy. The savage outlives the Controllers, and purification is destroyed by the deformed. The Enclave is anti-natal sovereignty's terminus, the planned extermination of the future's bearers, and its defeat by the contaminated is the decisive event of *felix contaminatio*.



CHAPTER 7

EDEN IN A BOX

The G.E.C.K., the Ingénu, and the Machine That Makes a Garden

Fallout 2 is a quest for a garden, and its quest object—the Garden of Eden Creation Kit—is the series' boldest theological satire: creation reduced to a product, Eden shipped in a case. This chapter argues that the Kit's ethical meaning is undecidable in itself and is decided only by who plants it, and it reads the Chosen One, a tribal sent out from Arroyo, as the latest heir of the ingénu, the naive outsider whose journey exposes the barbarism of the civilized.

7.1 THE KIT

The G.E.C.K. is a Vault-Tec package intended to let a vault's population build a settlement on emergence. In the sequel, drought and crop failure threaten Arroyo, the village founded by the exiled Vault Dweller, and its Elder sends the Chosen One in search of the Kit. It lies in Vault 13, the vault that cast out the Chosen One's ancestor. Sealed under its experimental design, Vault 13 never used it. The garden waited, unplanted, inside the enclosure that expelled the one who would found a people.

The Kit's theology is the theology of the commodity raised to cosmogony. Genesis narrates creation by word; Vault-Tec sells it by the unit. Creation *ex nihilo* becomes creation *ex kit*, and Marx's fetish attains its apotheosis: the commodity that produces a world. Heidegger's enframing, which reveals the earth as standing-reserve, here reaches creation itself, which now arrives with instructions. Yet the quest's structure resists the satire's closure. When the Chosen One recovers the Kit, the village that needed it has been raided and its people carried off to the Enclave's platform. The garden is obtained only when the community that would plant it has been abducted, and it cannot be planted until purity has been defeated.

7.2 THE GARDEN IN THE MACHINE

Leo Marx's *The Machine in the Garden* (1964) traced the American pastoral ideal through its recurrent interruption by technology, emblematized in Hawthorne's notebook entry of 1844 on a locomotive's whistle shattering the calm of Sleepy Hollow. Henry Nash Smith's *Virgin Land* (1950) reconstructed the myth of the West as the garden of the world, and Frederick Jackson Turner's frontier thesis (1893) located American character in a frontier the census of 1890 had declared closed. *Fallout* sets its catastrophe in California, the terminus of the westward course, and reopens the frontier by destroying the civilization that closed it.

The G.E.C.K. inverts Leo Marx's figure. It is not the machine in the garden but the garden in the machine: pastoral as product. Richard Slotkin's *Regeneration Through Violence* (1973) and *Gunfighter Nation* (1992) identified the American myth of renewal through frontier violence, and the sequel both indulges and complicates it. Its quest is paved with combat, but its end is cultivation rather than conquest. The frontier closes, this time, in a garden.

7.3 THE FORTUNATE FALL AND THE MODEST GARDEN

The Kit's name invokes Genesis, and the diptych's structure completes the invocation. The first game ends with an expulsion staged in the idiom of *Paradise Lost*; the second seeks to manufacture the lost garden. The *felix culpa* returns with a twist. The fall was not a sin but a war, and the garden is restored not by grace but by assembly.

Voltaire's *Candide* (1759) supplies the closest narrative model. Its naive hero traverses the catastrophes of his century—the Lisbon earthquake, war, the auto-da-fé, the enslaved man of Surinam whose hand was cut off when his finger caught in the sugar mill and whose leg was cut off when he tried to flee, both under the custom his Dutch owner enforced, and who tells Candide that this is the price at which Europe eats sugar—while his tutor Pangloss repeats the Leibnizian doctrine that all is for the best; the book ends with the injunction to cultivate our garden. *Fallout 2* is a *Candide* of the wasteland. Its hero passes through slavery in the Den, narcotics and prostitution in New Reno, religious fraud among the Hubologists, and the Panglossian self-satisfaction of Vault City, and ends with a garden. The two gardens nonetheless differ. Voltaire's is labor without metaphysics, the modest work that replaces speculation; the G.E.C.K. is metaphysics without labor, the promise of Eden without toil. The sequel's ending stands between them.

Haraway's cyborg, as Chapter 3 recalled, does not recognize Eden, because it has no origin to return to. The Kit's garden is a cyborg Eden, made rather than born, and its lack of origin is its emancipatory possibility: a garden without purity of origin is a garden open to mixture. The Master sought Eden through fusion; Vault-Tec sells it through fabrication; what the garden becomes depends on who plants it. Ernst Bloch's *The Principle of Hope* (1954–59) distinguished abstract utopia, compensatory wishing detached from real possibility, from concrete utopia, the anticipatory consciousness of the Not-Yet grounded in tendencies already at work. The Kit is an instrument of concrete utopia, and Vault City shows what becomes of it when abstract utopia—the dream of a perfect enclosure—takes it in hand.

7.4 THE INGÉNU

The Chosen One belongs to a venerable lineage. Montaigne's "Of Cannibals" (1580) turned the "savages" of Brazil into a mirror in which European barbarism appeared; Montesquieu's *Persian Letters* (1721) estranged Paris through foreign eyes; Voltaire's *L'Ingénu* (1767) sent a Huron into France to be imprisoned by its institutions. Huxley's John the Savage, raised on the Reservation, confronts the World State and is destroyed. The sequel's topography is Huxley's—from Arroyo, the Reservation, through Vault City, the World State, to the Enclave, the Controllers—but it completes Huxley's narrative differently, for the savage survives and wins.

The sequel radicalizes the device in its low-intelligence playthrough. A Chosen One of very low Intelligence cannot parse civilization's discourse at all and is reduced to grunts and malapropisms, yet can still traverse the world and save it. The extensive comic dialogue written for this path satirizes intellectual pretension and decouples heroism from cognition, although its humor frequently punches down, a tension Chapter 8 examines.

The trope carries its own contamination. The ingénu tradition borrowed the figure of the "savage" to criticize civilization while reproducing the colonial imagination that invented the savage, and the sequel inherits the double bind. Arroyo's spirit-talk and Sulik's bone-pierced nose and pidgin speech draw on primitivist codes; in San Francisco the Shi are rendered through an Orientalist iconography that Edward Said's *Orientalism* (1978) taught criticism to recognize. The series satirizes civilization's prejudices while reproducing its images, a residual colonial unconscious that the Conclusion counts among its complicities.

7.5 TRIALS, MYTH, AND THE TERROR OF HISTORY

The sequel begins in the Temple of Trials, a literal rendering of the road of trials in Joseph Campbell's *The Hero with a Thousand Faces* (1949). Arnold van Gennep's *The Rites of Passage* (1909) described initiation as separation, liminality, and incorporation, and Victor Turner's *The Ritual Process* (1969) dwelt on liminality, the condition of being betwixt and between, and on *communitas*, the anti-structural bond among equals stripped of status. Turner's *communitas* meets Esposito's here. The Chosen One is never incorporated; they remain permanently liminal—a tribal among citizens, a mutant among the pure—and their liminality is the condition of their power to found.

Mircea Eliade's *The Myth of the Eternal Return* (1949) described archaic ontology as the abolition of profane time through the repetition of archetypal acts, and modern historical existence as exposure to the terror of history. Arroyo lives in archaic time: its founding hero is a myth, its Vault suit a relic, its rites a repetition. The Chosen One's quest is an exit from the eternal return into the terror of history, a passage from Arroyo's mythic present to the Enclave's genocidal modernity.

The speculative tradition offers parallels. In *Mad Max Beyond Thunderdome* the lost children of the Crack in the Earth preserve the Tell of Captain Walker and Tomorrow-morrow Land and mistake Max for their messiah. Russell Hoban's *Riddley Walker* (1980) imagines a post-nuclear Kent assembling myth from fragments of the pre-war world while its powers labor to reinvent the explosive that destroyed it. Miller's *Canticle* completes the cycle with a second nuclear war. The sequel holds recurrence open—the Enclave's remnant persists at Navarro, and the republic expands—but it plants the garden in the interval. Black Isle's next major work, *Planescape: Torment* (1999), would make the series' implicit question its explicit refrain: "What can change the nature of a man?"

7.6 VAULT CITY AND THE NEW ARROYO

The decisive juxtaposition is internal to the sequel. The G.E.C.K. has been used before the sequel begins. By the series' lore, Vault 15's Kit founded Shady Sands, the seed of the republic whose Rangers hunt slavers, and Vault 8's founded Vault City, an Eden with servants. The Kit is ethically underdetermined; it can build an Omelas as easily as an Arroyo. The ending supplies the counter-image. Arroyo is rebuilt with the Kit, together with the liberated survivors of Vault 13: the community the Vault expelled and the community the Enclave abducted, the exposed and the immunized, plant the garden side by side.

The contrast between the two gardens is the sequel's final argument. The garden redeems only when it is open—when it is planted not by those who sealed themselves in but by those whom the Vault cast out and those whom the last sovereign tried to use. Kant's hospitality, extended to the garden, becomes a principle of cultivation. The Garden, the third device of this thesis, is the Vault's antithesis only on that condition: that its gate stands open.



CHAPTER 8

THE LUDIC ETHICS OF MUTABILITY

S.P.E.C.I.A.L., Karma, and Procedural Phronesis

THE GAMES ARGUE THROUGH their rules as well as their stories, and their rules converge on a single claim: the player is the one fully mutable being in a world organized by the immutable. This chapter reads the diptych's systems—attributes, traits, intelligence, karma, the clock, violence, and the architecture of quests—as philosophical propositions, and it closes by arguing that the games' generic impurity is the formal correlate of *felix contaminatio*.

8.1 SYSTEMS AS PROPOSITIONS

Ian Bogost's *Persuasive Games* (2007) named the capacity of rules to make arguments procedural rhetoric. Espen Aarseth's *Cybertext* (1997) defined ergodic texts as those requiring nontrivial effort to traverse; Janet Murray's *Hamlet on the Holodeck* (1997) identified agency, immersion, and transformation as the aesthetic pleasures of digital narrative; Gonzalo Frasca (2003) distinguished simulation from narrative as modes of representation; Alexander Galloway's *Gaming* (2006) read games as allegories of control; McKenzie Wark's *Gamer Theory* (2007) diagnosed a world remade as gamespace; Henry Jenkins (2004) described the environmental storytelling of explorable worlds. Each lens finds in *Fallout* an exemplary object, and together they license the protocol announced at the outset. The clock is a claim about finitude; the barter screen, about value; the attribute schema, about the human; the intelligence threshold, about language; karma and reputation, about morality and recognition; the multiple-solution quest, about practical reason; the epilogue, about judgment.

8.2 S.P.E.C.I.A.L.: THE ANTHROPOMETRY OF THE SELF

Every character begins as seven numbers—Strength, Perception, Endurance, Charisma, Intelligence, Agility, Luck—distributed within a fixed budget and supplemented by tagged skills and by optional traits that trade an advantage for a disadvantage. Character creation is an act of design. Francis Galton's Anthropometric Laboratory, opened at the International Health Exhibition in London in 1884, measured visitors' faculties as data for a science of heredity. The player at the creation screen is Galton's heir, composing a human being from quantities. It is the one moment in the diptych when the player occupies the position of Vault-Tec or the Master: the designer of bodies.

Philip K. Dick's *Do Androids Dream of Electric Sheep?* (1968) gives the acronym an uncanny resonance. In Dick's irradiated San Francisco, "specials" are citizens whose genes the radioactive dust has damaged, who fail the tests of mental faculty, and who are barred from emigration and effectively from the reproductive future of the species; the "chickenhead" J. R. Isidore is the novel's tender exemplar. Whether or not the rhyme was intended, *Fallout* converts Dick's exclusionary classification into a universal condition. Everyone is S.P.E.C.I.A.L. In a world that fallout has touched entirely, every body is measured and every body is marked: the special has been democratized.

Sartre's *Existentialism Is a Humanism* (1946) declared that existence precedes essence. The attribute sheet resembles an essence fixed at birth, yet the character becomes through choices no number determines. The traits sharpen the paradox. Bloody Mess, Jinxed, Gifted, Skilled, Good Natured, and Chem Reliant are chosen flaws and chosen gifts—Heideggerian thrownness elected rather than suffered. The game lets the player choose how they are thrown.

Progression supplies the antithesis to the vat. Experience accrues, and at intervals the character acquires perks, slowly and by choice, so that the role-playing game becomes a ludic *Bildungsroman* in the tradition of Goethe's *Wilhelm Meister's Apprenticeship* (1795–96), a self-formation through experience. The perk system is the anti-FEV: evolution by experience rather than immersion, gradual, chosen, and never complete. The Master's virus transforms a body in an instant and forecloses its future; the player's levels transform a character over a lifetime and keep it open.

Luck makes contingency an attribute. Roger Caillois's *Man, Play and Games* (1958) placed *alea*, chance, among the fundamental forms of play; Bernard Williams (1976) and Thomas Nagel (1979) named moral luck, the dependence of moral assessment on factors beyond the agent's control. The Jinxed trait gives the concept a social form. It makes critical failures more frequent for everyone in combat, the player included: misfortune becomes a commons, a contagious contingency—*felix contaminatio* in miniature.

8.3 THE SPEECH OF THE UNINTELLIGENT

A character whose Intelligence falls below a threshold speaks in grunts and malapropisms, and the world responds with confusion, pity, or contempt; the sequel elaborates this path with remarkable thoroughness. Wittgenstein's *Tractatus* (5.6) holds that the limits of my language mean the limits of my world. The game demurs. Its low-intelligence character's world exceeds their language: they can still travel, trade, fight, and on many routes accomplish what the articulate accomplish by talking. Agency is decoupled from articulacy.

Miranda Fricker's *Epistemic Injustice* (2007) defined testimonial injustice as the credibility deficit a speaker suffers through prejudice. The low-intelligence character is a permanent object of testimonial injustice whom the game nonetheless allows to save the world. Two criticisms must nevertheless be entered. The path's comedy frequently borrows the cadences of ableist ridicule. More structurally, the route to peace celebrated in Chapter 3, the refutation of the Master, requires high Intelligence and a trained Speech skill. The game distributes peaceful resolution according to cognitive capacity, a Platonic residue that reserves persuasion for philosopher-kings. It is more egalitarian in its violence than in its peace.

8.4 KARMA, REPUTATION, AND THE LEDGER

Karma is a single moral ledger, a number that rises with good deeds and falls with bad ones; the sequel supplements it with reputations in individual towns and with epithets—Childkiller, Slaver, Made Man, Grave Digger, Champion, Berserker—that follow the character through the world. Nietzsche's second essay in *On the Genealogy of Morality* (§§4–8) derived the moral concept of guilt, *Schuld*, from the material concept of debts, *Schulden*, and morality itself from the relation of creditor and debtor. Karma is moral bookkeeping, the genealogy of morals compressed into a counter.

The sequel's split between global karma and local reputation reproduces Hegel's distinction in the *Philosophy of Right* (1820) between *Moralität*, the abstract morality of individual conscience, and *Sittlichkeit*, the ethical life of concrete communities. A character may be a hero in one town and a pariah in the next; the ethical is plural and situated, and abstract virtue does not guarantee recognition. The epithets restore Goffman's stigma to the face of the world, and the most notorious, Childkiller, provoked a real immunitary response: the first game was refused release in Europe until its children were removed, the European versions of both games shipped without them, the German versions also lost their most violent death animations, and the sequel jokes about the absence in a Vault City conversation. Censorship immunized the market against the text. Miguel Sicart's *The Ethics of Computer Games* (2009) argues that ethical gameplay requires reflective players rather than moral meters. *Fallout*'s karma is crude, but its epilogues perform a richer, consequentialist judgment, assessing each settlement by what the player's choices made of it.

The epilogue completes this moral metaphysics as eschatology. Revelation imagines the dead judged out of the books according to their works (20:12), and both games end by opening such books: settlement by settlement, the narrator pronounces what the player's deeds made of each community, beyond appeal and beyond further action. The judgment is consequentialist rather than retributive and falls on towns rather than souls. It is a Last Judgment without a judge, delivered by the same narrator whose refrain has already declared that the one thing his books cannot alter, war, will never change.

8.5 THE CLOCK

The first game allows one hundred and fifty days to find the water chip, a deadline the Hub's water caravans can extend by a hundred days, and as first released it ran a second clock of five hundred days toward the Master's invasion, which the caravans shortened by the same hundred; patch 1.1, issued after the clock proved unpopular, replaced that limit with thirteen years. The clock is a *memento mori*. Heidegger's analysis of being-toward-death in *Being and Time* (1927) located authentic existence in the anticipation of one's own finitude, and Jesper Juul's *The Art of Failure* (2013) described the paradox by which games make us seek out the failure we dislike. The water chip clock is the procedural form of both. It is also the Overseer's Paradox rendered as time: every reprieve opens the door, and the Vault's survival is measured in days of exposure.

8.6 BLOODY MESS

The games' deaths are notoriously graphic—bodies melted into puddles, burned to ash, cut in half, riddled—and the Bloody Mess trait guarantees that every death will be the most spectacular available. Burke's *Philosophical Enquiry* (I.xiv–xv) confessed that we take no small delight in the real misfortunes and pains of others, and the isometric camera supplies the safe distance that makes such delight possible. Yet the trait does something more: it names the appetite it satisfies. The player who selects Bloody Mess confesses a desire on a menu. The violence is spectacle and critique at once, framed by an opening newsreel in which American soldiers in power armor shoot a kneeling, unarmed man and wave to the camera, and processed through a grotesque comedy in Bakhtin's sense, in which the body's dissolution provokes a laughter that is never quite innocent. Slotkin's regeneration through violence is offered and, in the same gesture, exposed.

8.7 PROCEDURAL PHRONESIS AND THE LAW OF GENRE

The designers' governing principle, that problems should admit several solutions—combat, stealth, dialogue, technical skill—makes the games schools of practical reason. Aristotle's *phronēsis* (*Nicomachean Ethics* VI.5, 1140a–b) is the capacity to deliberate well about particulars, a wisdom that cannot be deduced from rules. *Fallout* trains it. The right course is discerned in the situation, against a town's history, a companion's loyalties, and the player's own record, and no rule settles in advance whether Gizmo should be exposed or Gecko saved.

The pre-made characters make the structure explicit. *Fallout* offered Max Stone, Natalia Dubrovhsky, and Albert Cole; *Fallout 2* offered Narg, Mingun, and Chitsa: in each case a fighter, a thief, and a diplomat. Plato's tripartite soul (*Republic* IV, 436a–441c) divides into spirit, appetite, and reason, and the three archetypes map onto it with preci-

sion: *thumos* fights, *epithumia* acquires by cunning, *logos* persuades. The three paths through every quest are the three parts of the soul made into routes.

The form, finally, is the argument. Derrida's "The Law of Genre" (1980) proposed that the law of genre is a law of impurity, a principle of contamination by which every text participates in genres without belonging to them. The diptych is generically impure in the extreme: a role-playing game crossed with satire, the Western, hard-boiled noir, the atomic B-movie, the picaresque, and slapstick. Its special encounters—a Pythonesque bridge-keeper and holy hand grenade, a whale and a bowl of petunias fallen from the sky, a stranded starship shuttle, a blue police box—are Bakhtinian carnival, intertextual contamination as play. A contaminated world receives a contaminated form, and the player, the one fully mutable being within it, is the agent of *felix contaminatio*.



CONCLUSION

FELIX CONTAMINATIO

Toward a Mutant Political Theology

THE INTERPLAY-ERA *Fallout* is a single argument about sovereignty and birth. Its three great powers—the Vault, the Vat, and the Enclave—attempt to master time by abolishing birth, and its two protagonists, the exile and the exile's descendant, defeat them by beginning. This conclusion assembles the argument, states its central concept in full, tests it against the speculative tradition, and confronts its limits.

C.1 THREE SOVEREIGNTIES AGAINST BIRTH

The Overseer arrests time: the Vault was designed to keep a population unchanged for two centuries, and it expels the one member who changes. The Master replaces generation with fabrication: his vats make a people that cannot be born and cannot bear. The Enclave exterminates: its virus would kill the impure majority in whom any future would have to be born. A fourth power, internal to the polis, completes the series: the slaver, whose trade inflicts what Patterson called natal alienation, the severance of the enslaved from ancestry and descent. Stasis, sterility, extermination, and natal alienation are four forms of a single anti-natal sovereignty.

Against them stands exilic natality. The Vault Dweller, expelled for having changed, founds Arroyo and, through the rescue of Tandi, seeds the republic. The Chosen One, born of that exile and classified as a mutant, destroys the Enclave and plants the garden with the people the Enclave abducted. Arendt's natality, the capacity to begin that is rooted in the fact of birth, here acquires a condition *The Human Condition* did not specify: in the wasteland, beginning belongs to those who have been cast out. The power to begin is a power of the exposed.

One objection must be met directly, because the argument is easily misheard. Natality in Arendt's sense is not fertility. It names the arrival of newcomers—every person who enters a world that preceded them and can begin something unforeseen in it—and it belongs to the infertile as fully as to anyone. The super mutants' sterility indicts the Master's project, not the sterile. What condemns Unity is that it abolishes plurality by fusing every newcomer into a single fabricated kind, so that nothing new can arrive. Broken Hills proves the point from the other side: its super mutants cannot bear children, yet they found, welcome, and protect, and the town renews itself by admitting strangers. Donna Haraway's later slogan "Make Kin Not Babies!" (*Staying with the Trouble*, 2016) names the alternative the Master perverts, for he makes kin by compulsion and immersion, while Broken Hills makes kin by consent. Anti-natal sovereignty is defined by the foreclosure of newcomers—through stasis, fusion, extermination, and the severance of the enslaved from their kin—never by anyone's capacity to reproduce.

C.2 WAR NEVER CHANGES: A DEFINITION

The refrain can now be read as a definition. War is the sovereign decision about inside and outside—about who is sheltered and who exposed, who lives and who dies—and that decision is the immutable, the same in Rome, in Madrid, in Berlin, and behind the cog-shaped door. Against it the series sets the mutant, the one who has been changed. The opposition inverts Heraclitus. For the Ephesian, war was the father of all change; for *Fallout*, war fathers nothing. Its fathers—the Overseer with his sealed population, the Master with his sterile Children, the President with his purified remnant—are fathers of nothing. What is born in the wasteland is born of the cast-out. War never changes. The mutant does.

The reading also illuminates the series' relation to Nietzsche's eternal recurrence, which *The Gay Science* (§341) proposed as a test of affirmation. *Fallout*'s recurrence of war is not an object of affirmation but a diagnosis: recurrence is the signature of sovereignty, not of life. Life does not recur; it mutates. The series therefore refuses the cyclical fatalism its refrain seems to announce, locating history's openness not in the end of war, which it never promises, but in the irreducible changefulness of everything war cannot keep inside.

C.3 FELIX CONTAMINATIO

The thesis's governing concept can now be stated in five registers.

Ontologically, fallout is remainder. There is no pure outside to which one might retreat and no uncontaminated body from which one might begin again. When the Enclave classifies the wasteland's entire population as mutants, it states from the side of purity a truth the series affirms from the side of life: contamination is universal.

Politically, community is shared exposure. Esposito's *communitas*, bound by a common debt rather than a common property, finds its anatomy in Jean-Luc Nancy's *The Inoperative Community* (1983), which rejects community conceived as a work or a fusion—community producing its own essence, the totalitarian communion of which the Master's Unity is a perfect instance—in favor of community as the exposure of singular beings to one another. Maurice Blanchot's *The Unavowable Community* (1983) and Agamben's *The Coming Community* (1990) extend the thought. Broken Hills and the new Arroyo are inoperative communities in Nancy's sense: not fusions but cohabitations of humans, ghouls, mutants, tribals, and vault dwellers who share nothing but their exposure.

Ethically, felix contaminatio is hospitality and vulnerability. Kant's cosmopolitan right of hospitality and Derrida's *Of Hospitality* (1997), which measures every conditional welcome against an unconditional hospitality it can never fully realize, name the ethic of the open door. Emmanuel Levinas's *Otherwise than Being* (1974) describes the subject as exposure, the passivity of a skin offered to the other, and Butler's precariousness

names the shared vulnerability that grounds obligation. The ghoul's broken skin is Levinas's figure made literal.

Theologically, felix contaminatio is a *felix culpa* without a redeemer. The fall is fortunate not because it summons a savior but because it forecloses purity, the fantasy that animated Vault-Tec, the Master, and the Enclave alike. There is no messiah in the wasteland, only the remnant, and the remnant suffices.

Ludically, felix contaminatio is the form of play itself: nonlinear, mutable, generically impure, measured by an attribute schema that makes every body special.

C.4 THE DOOR THAT WOULD NOT CLOSE

The series' first image is a closed door, cog-shaped and colossal. Its hidden emblem is the opposite: the door of Vault 12, engineered never to close. Vault-Tec designed it as an experiment in exposure, and the experiment produced the ghouls—the irradiated, decaying, long-lived remnant whose city, Necropolis, is a city of the dead in which the dead are living. Necropolitics designed the open door; the open door outlived necropolitics. The ghouls of Vault 12 are the series' unacknowledged ethical origin, the proof that the exposed endure. If the cog-shaped door is war's emblem, the door that would not close is the emblem of what war cannot change.

C.5 THE SPECULATIVE TRADITION RECONSIDERED

The concept clarifies *Fallout*'s place in the speculative canon. Against Miller's *Canticle*, it grants recurrence but refuses fatalism, locating hope in mutation rather than in the custody of memory. Against Wyndham's *Chrysalids* and Clarke's *Childhood's End*, it refuses evolutionary supersession, whether celebrated as Sealand's right or sublimated as the Overmind's transcendence. It stands nearer to Butler's *Xenogenesis*, which refuses both human purity and coerced fusion while conceding the necessity of mixture, and to Hoban's *Riddley Walker*, whose broken language is a remnant that remembers.

Its closest kin is Hayao Miyazaki's *Nausicaä of the Valley of the Wind*, whose manga, completed in 1994, ends with a revelation and a refusal. Nausicaä learns that the toxic forest is purifying the world, that her contemporaries were engineered to live in the poisoned world and would perish in a purified one, and that a crypt holds the means to restore a purified humanity once the cleansing is complete. She refuses the crypt's custodians and destroys it, choosing the contaminated life that exists over the pure life promised. Three years before *Fallout*, Miyazaki gave *felix contaminatio* its purest statement. Cormac McCarthy's *The Road* (2006) would later ask its survivors to carry the fire; in *Fallout* the fire is mutation itself.

C.6 LIMITS AND COMPLICITIES

No reading of the diptych can be pure, and by its own logic this one should not be. The series traffics in primitivist codes in Arroyo and in Sulik, and in Orientalist ones among the Shi. Its low-intelligence comedy borrows the cadences of ableist ridicule. Its sexual comedy, from New Reno's studio to its brothels, often laughs at the exploited rather than with them. Its pleasure in violence is confessed but not renounced. Its karma reduces ethics to arithmetic, and its most celebrated peace, the refutation of the Master, is reserved for the cognitively privileged. The games were commodities made under industrial pressure by a company whose financial collapse ended in the franchise's sale to Bethesda Softworks, completed in 2007; the series' afterlife is itself a fallout of the market it satirized. *Felix contaminatio* applies to criticism too. There is no position outside the contamination from which the games could be judged clean or condemned whole; the critique stands inside the wasteland it describes.

C.7 AFTERLIVES AND THE QUESTION OF CHANGE

The question of change migrated with the series' makers. *Planescape: Torment* (1999), written by Chris Avellone and a Black Isle team that included veterans of the sequel, built its entire inquiry around the question, quoted in Chapter 7, of what can change the nature of a man. Troika's *Arcanum* (2001) staged Weber's disenchantment as a war between technology and magic, and *Vampire: The Masquerade – Bloodlines* (2004) explored another hidden society living off the bodies of the exposed. *The Outer Worlds* (2019), co-directed by Cain and Boyarsky at Obsidian Entertainment, returned to corporate sovereignty in a colonial key, Vault-Tec's logic exported to the stars. The Bethesda-era games monumentalized Vault-Tec's kitsch, and the 2024 television adaptation placed the corporation's designs on the post-war future at the center of the catastrophe, confirming in a mass medium what the diptych had argued in 1997 and 1998: the shelter was the weapon.

This thesis is dated 23 October 2026, fifty-one years to the day before the date the series' chronology assigns to the Great War. The interval is not a prophecy. It is a reminder that vaults are built before the wars they anticipate, that the decision about the door precedes the bombs, and that the time in which sovereignty prepares its enclosures is always the present. *Fallout*'s wager is that the door can be held open—that the exposed, the exiled, and the changed are not the casualties of history but its bearers. War never changes. That is why everything else must.

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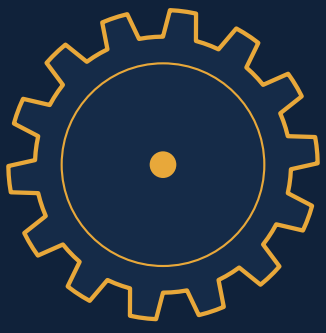
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FILE 11 · INDEX TERMS

KEYWORDS

Fallout · *Fallout 2* · Interplay Productions · Black Isle Studios · Tim Cain · Leonard Boyarsky · post-apocalyptic fiction · nuclear criticism · retrofuturism · hauntology · futures past · civil defense · Cold War culture · immunity paradigm · immunopolitics · biopolitics · necropolitics · political theology · sovereignty · state of exception · natality · natal alienation · exilic natality · felix culpa · felix contaminatio · Overseer's Paradox · Vault-Tec · Forced Evolutionary Virus · Garden of Eden Creation Kit · eugenics · human experimentation · nuclear testing · posthumanism · cyborg theory · personhood · Allegory of the Cave · pharmakos · scapegoat · master–slave dialectic · Übermensch · general will · end of history · inoperative community · hospitality · procedural rhetoric · ergodic literature · ludic ethics · phronesis · role-playing games · game studies · speculative fiction · comparative literature



War never changes. That is why everything else must.

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